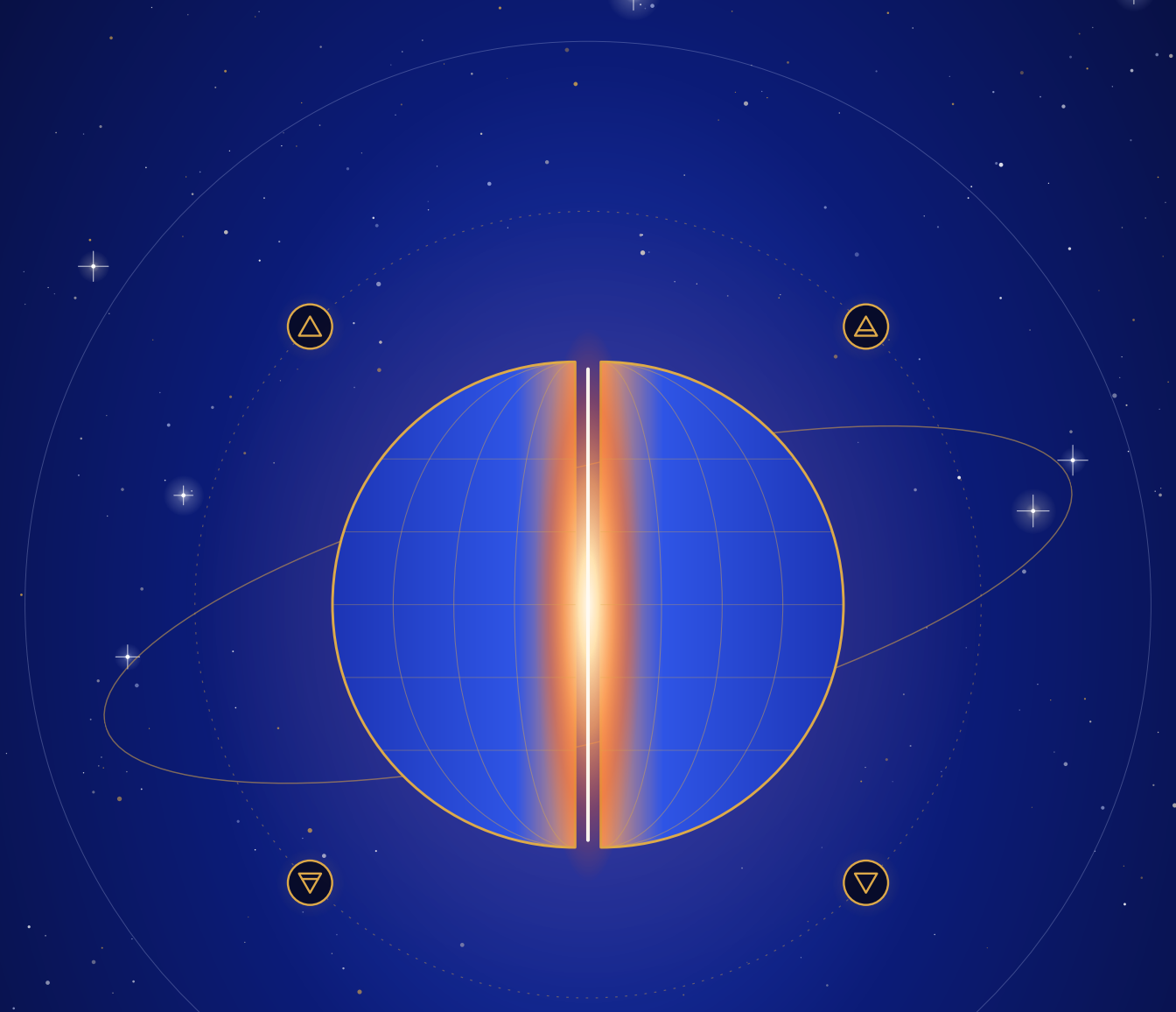
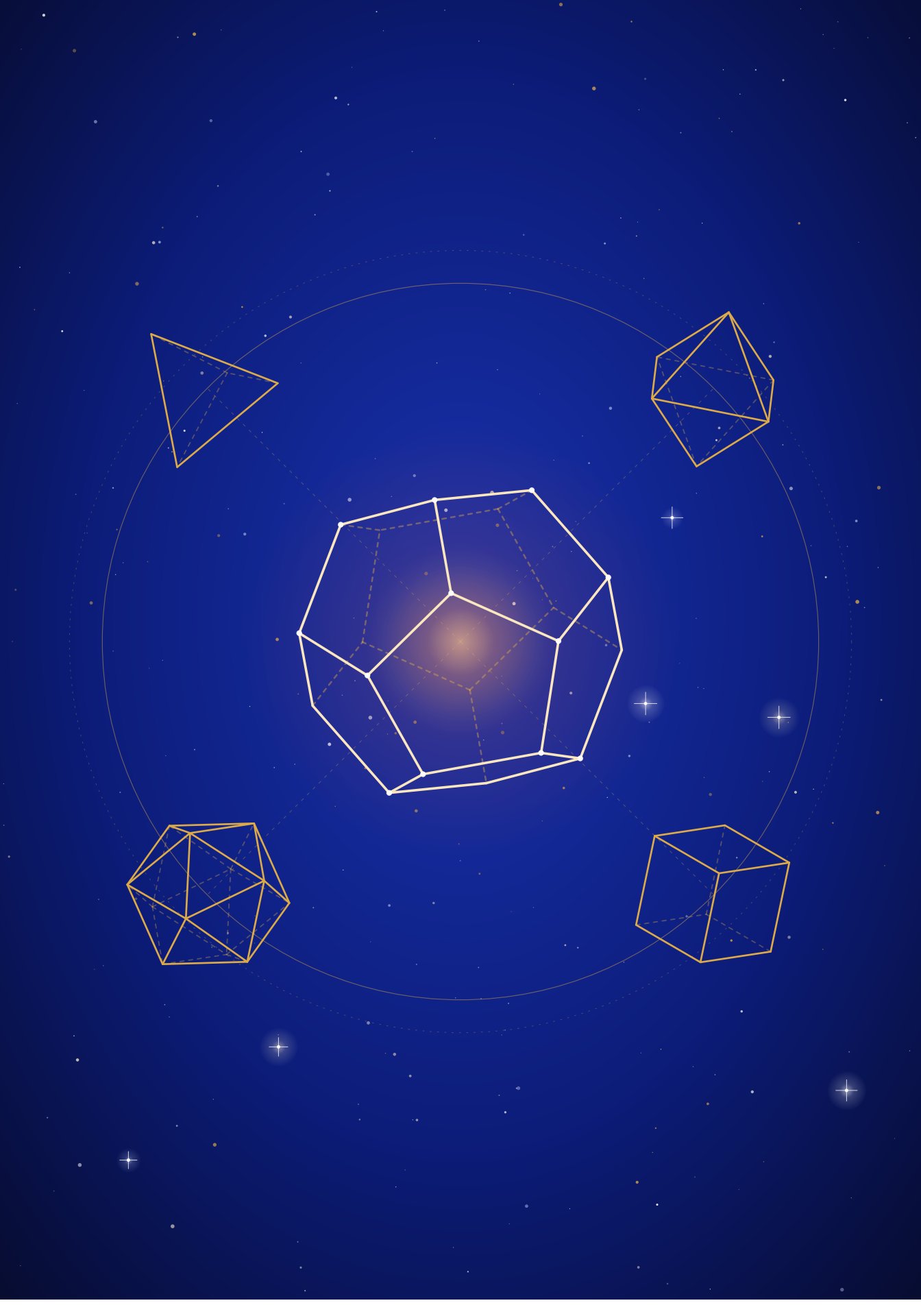


The Quintessence of the Between

Metaxic Soteriology, Osculatory Theodicy, and the Sociocosmic Tetrasomia of Luc Besson and Robert Mark Kamen's The Fifth Element *(1997)*

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Abstract

This dissertation argues that Luc Besson and Robert Mark Kamen's *The Fifth Element* (1997), habitually dismissed as a camp Euro-blockbuster of design without depth, is among the most cosmologically and theologically overdetermined artefacts of late-twentieth-century popular cinema, and that its titular noun conceals a deliberate category error whose resolution constitutes the film's philosophical achievement. The four elemental stones are substances; the "Supreme Being" regenerated from a single cell of a severed hand appears to be a fifth substance; yet the narrative withholds efficacy from every substance it stages—stone, body, genome, weapon, state, market, medium—and confers it only upon a relation: the love declared by a mortal to a god in the final seconds before cosmic impact. The fifth element, in the only sense in which the film permits anything to *work*, is not an element at all. It is an interval.

The argument proceeds by a constellational method assembled from Aby Warburg's doctrine of the afterlife (*Nachleben*) of ancient pathos-formulae, Claude Lévi-Strauss's account of myths that think themselves in their tellers without their knowledge, and Walter Benjamin's figure of the idea as constellation. Three genealogies are reconstructed. The first is cosmological: from Empedocles' four roots governed by Love (*Philotēs*) and Strife (*Neikos*), through Plato's dodecahedral fifth, Aristotle's aether and the "fifth nature" of mind reported by Cicero, to the Renaissance *spiritus mundi* of Ficino and Agrippa, in which the quintessence is explicitly defined as a *medium*, and to the apocalyptic alchemy of John of Rupescissa, for whom the distilled quintessence was an instrument against the Antichrist. The second is mythological: the periodic chaos-combat of

Ra against Apophis, Marduk against Tiamat, the Zoroastrian Saoshyant born from preserved seed, the Vaiṣṇava *avatāra* who descends age after age, and the Mexica Fifth Sun with its New Fire, within which the film's five-thousand-year cycle of evil and its Egyptian temple-weapon become legible as a cosmogram. The third is specifically French: Bastiat's broken window, Maistre's providential violence, the Revolutionary cult of the *Être suprême*, Bergson's universe as a machine for the making of gods, Teilhard's cosmic energetics of love, Breton's redemptive *femme-enfant*, Yves Klein's void, the *réalisme fantastique* of Pauwels and Bergier, *Métal hurlant*, and the *cinéma du look*—a lineage that explains why the Supreme Being of a Franco-American blockbuster arrives as a deist abstraction requiring erotic completion.

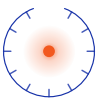
Analytical chapters treat the regeneration sequence as the literalisation of Bergson's machine and the heir of Villiers de l'Isle-Adam's *L'Ève future*, coinciding to the quarter-year with the announcement of the first mammal cloned from an adult somatic cell; Zorg's glass-breaking sermon as a Mephistophelean and Panglossian economy of destruction, refuted at once by Bastiat's "unseen" and by the unremunerated gesture of care (*Fürsorge*) that rescues him from choking; the Great Evil, which grows when fired upon, as René Girard's mimetic Satan; and Leeloo's alphabetical ingestion of the human archive—arriving at War after having passed Love only as a word—as a restaging of the Fall in which the deity rather than the creature eats of the tree of knowledge and despairs, posing Camus's fundamental question about whether life is worth living at the scale of a species.

The dissertation also records where the film's practice falls short of its theory. It plays its hero's non-consensual kiss on an unconscious woman partly as comedy and never reckons with it; it casts extraterrestrials as the benevolent custodians of an Egyptian temple in the year Britain declared Egypt a protectorate; and it draws part of its carnival from racial and queer stereotype. These failures qualify the synthesis without refuting it, and they are stated where they arise.

Against this background the dissertation advances an original synthesis, *metaxic quintessentialism*, articulated in four propositions. The **pemptic inversion** holds that the fifth is not a substance but an interval, Diotima's *metaxu*, in which Empedocles had already located Love "among" the elements while Strife stands "apart." The **theurgic inversion** holds that

the divine acts only when humanly loved, converging with Lurianic *yiḥud*, Hans Jonas's post-Auschwitz God, and Etty Hillesum's resolve to help God. The **osculatory theodicy** holds that the problem of evil is answered not by argument but by a kiss, as in Dostoevsky's Grand Inquisitor, Bernard of Clairvaux's Christology of the kiss as Mediator, and the Talmudic cherubim whose embrace housed the divine presence. The **sociocosmic tetrasomia** holds that the film redistributes the four classical elements across the four institutional powers of late modernity—territorial state (earth), armaments industry (fire), broadcast media (air), and spectacle-art (water)—none of which can administer salvation. Two corollaries follow: that the film's notorious carnivalesque tonality is not a failure of seriousness but the Bakhtinian instrument by which cosmic terror is disarmed and sincerity smuggled past irony; and that the Evil's transformation into a dead moon, rather than its annihilation, encodes a cosmogonic ethics of periodic, renewable love in place of final victory.

Epigraphs



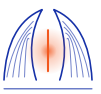
"Time not important. Only life important."

— The Mondoshawan to the priest, Egypt, 1914, in *The Fifth Element* (1997)



Fire and water and earth and the boundless height of air, and accursed Strife apart from them, equal in weight on every side, and Love among them, equal in length and breadth.

— Empedocles, DK 31 B17.18–20 (translation mine)



And there I will meet with thee, and I will commune with thee from above the mercy seat, from between the two cherubims.

— Exodus 25:22 (Authorized Version)



l'amor che move il sole e l'altre stelle

— Dante, *Paradiso* XXXIII.145

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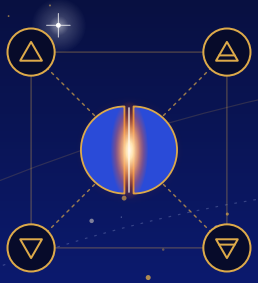
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Introduction

Quinta Essentia, Quinta Relatio

The Category Error in the Title

0.1 The Object and Its Disrepute

The Fifth Element opened the fiftieth Festival de Cannes on 7 May 1997. Produced by Gaumont on a budget reported at roughly US$90 million—then the largest committed to a European production—and distributed in North America by Columbia Pictures, it was shot in English with an Anglo-American cast (Bruce Willis, Milla Jovovich, Gary Oldman, Ian Holm, Chris Tucker), designed in part by the two most celebrated draughtsmen of the Franco-Belgian *bande dessinée*, Jean Giraud (Mœbius) and Jean-Claude Mézières, costumed by Jean Paul Gaultier, scored by Éric Serra, photographed by Thierry Arbogast, and realised in its effects by Digital Domain. It returned approximately US$263 million worldwide. Its story descends from a manuscript Besson began as an adolescent in the mid-1970s, reportedly organised around a protagonist named Zaltman Bléros, and reached screenplay form in collaboration with Robert Mark Kamen, whose *The Karate Kid* (1984) had already demonstrated a gift for lodging an initiatory philosophy of balance inside the most commercial of American genres.

The film's critical fortunes have been governed by two prejudices. The first is the French critical establishment's suspicion of the *cinéma du look*—the label Raphaël Bassan (1989) attached to Jean-Jacques Beineix, Besson, and Leos Carax—as an advertising aesthetic that privileged image over meaning, surface over interiority, and the grammar of the music video over that of the auteur (Austin 1996; Hayward 1998; Hayward and Powrie 2006). The second is the Anglophone habit of receiving the film as camp: a riot of couture, falsetto broadcasting, and an asymmetrical villain's coiffure, whose metaphysics could be enjoyed precisely because it could not be believed. Both prejudices converge on a single verdict: the film possesses a cosmology but no thought.

Within the theory of science-fiction cinema, the film has been placed in the vocabulary that Vivian Sobchack's *Screening Space* (1987) and Scott Bukatman's *Terminal Identity* (1993) made standard: the genre's privileging of spectacle over narrative, the special-effects sublime, and the mutation of the human subject in technological space. That vocabulary describes the film's surfaces accurately. It has not been brought to bear on the film's metaphysics, which is the gap this dissertation addresses.

This dissertation reverses that verdict without denying its premises. The surface is indeed naive, maximal, and derivative; but naivety, maximalism, and derivation are the very conditions under which archaic cosmological materials survive in mass culture. The reproach of naivety misidentifies the object. *The Fifth Element* does not assert, as a proposition, that love conquers all. It poses a problem in the metaphysics of substance and relation, in theodicy, and in the political economy of violence, and it resolves that problem by a performative act whose structure has exact antecedents in pre-Socratic cosmology, Platonic erotology, medieval mystical theology, Lurianic Kabbalah, Revolutionary civil religion, and post-Holocaust Jewish thought. That the film reaches these antecedents through comic books, opera, couture, and an action star is not an embarrassment to be explained away. It is the datum to be explained.

The Diegesis in Brief 0.2

Egypt, 1914. An archaeologist deciphers a temple inscription depicting a weapon of four elemental stones disposed around a fifth, anthropomor-

phic figure. The Mondoshawans, armoured extraterrestrial custodians, arrive to remove the stones and the sarcophagus of the fifth element, because the war about to break across Europe has rendered Earth unsafe; they entrust a key to a priest whose order will transmit the secret across generations, and promise to return when the Evil returns. Asked about the interval, the Mondoshawan answers with the dictum that serves this study as its first epigraph: time does not matter; life does.

The twenty-third century (conventionally dated 2263). A vast, dark, sentient mass approaches Earth. A warship fires upon it; it absorbs the assault, swells, and annihilates the ship. The Mondoshawan vessel returning the elements is destroyed by Mangalore mercenaries in the hire of the armaments industrialist Jean-Baptiste Emanuel Zorg, who is himself in telecommunicative servitude to the Evil, which he addresses as Mr. Shadow. From a gloved hand recovered from the wreck, government scientists regenerate a humanoid female whose genome exceeds the human in informational density by orders of magnitude. She breaches her enclosure, flees across the vertical megacity of New York, leaps from a ledge, and falls through stratified traffic into the cab of Korben Dallas, a former special-forces major now driving a taxi. She speaks a "Divine Language"; Father Vito Cornelius, heir of the 1914 priest, recognises her as the Supreme Being, the fifth element, Leeloo.

The stones prove to have been entrusted to the Diva Plavalaguna, an alien soprano performing aboard the luxury liner *Fhloston Paradise*. The state rigs a consumer contest to send Korben there; Leeloo travels as his wife, brandishing her Multipass; the radio host Ruby Rhod broadcasts the voyage. During the Diva's recital—the mad scene of Donizetti's *Lucia di Lammermoor* dissolving into Serra's electronic "Diva Dance"—the Mangalores attack. The Diva is shot and, dying, delivers to Korben the stones that lie inside her body, charging him with Leeloo's need for his help and his love. Zorg, having seized an empty case, returns for the stones and perishes in a detonation he does not control. Meanwhile Leeloo has ingested the human archive alphabetically and, arriving at the entry for War, collapses into despair. In the Egyptian temple, with the Evil minutes and then seconds from impact, the four stones are opened by their elements—breath, sweat, a handful of sand, the flame of Korben's last match. Leeloo asks why life should be saved, given what human beings do with it. Korben declares

that he loves her and kisses her. Light issues from her body, strikes the Evil, and extinguishes it; the mass cools into an inert planetoid suspended in Earth's sky. In a coda, the couple, sequestered in the laboratory's recovery chamber, are unavailable to the President's congratulations.

The Problem: An Element That Is Not an Element

0.3

In the classical tradition the fifth element is a *substance*: Aristotle's aether, the incorruptible body of the heavens; the alchemists' *quinta essentia*, distilled, rarefied, preservative; the Indian *ākāśa*, the subtlest of the great elements. The film appears to honour this tradition. Its fifth element is a body, regenerated in a machine and certified by a scientist as perfect; the Supreme Being, in a vocabulary that is at once deist and Revolutionary, is a *being*. Yet the narrative systematically withholds efficacy from substance. The stones, without the actions of human bodies, are inert. The Supreme Being, after reading the archive, is inert. The military's ordnance, the most concentrated material force the diegesis contains, does worse than nothing: it feeds the Evil. What finally *works* is neither stone nor body nor weapon but an utterance and a gesture passing between two persons.

Gilbert Ryle (1949) defined a category mistake by the visitor who, having been shown the colleges, libraries, and laboratories of Oxford, asks where the University is—as though the University were one more building alongside the others rather than the way they are organised. *The Fifth Element* stages Ryle's error and its correction. Every power in the film—the Federated Territories, Zorg Industries, the Mangalores—searches for the fifth element as one more object alongside the four, an asset to be possessed, transported, contained, or sold. The film literalises the futility of this search with a stroke of almost scholastic exactness: the case for which Zorg kills, and for which he dies, is empty. The fifth element is not one more stone. It is the manner in which the four are bound.

The point can be sharpened through liturgical vocabulary. In Christian sacramental theology the bread and wine of the Eucharist are "the elements," and the epiclesis is the invocation by which the Spirit descends upon them and transforms them. The temple sequence is an epiclesis in this precise sense: elements offered by human bodies, a priest presiding, an invocation, a descent. But the invocation is not a prayer addressed upward.

It is a declaration addressed to the deity herself, without which she will not act. The consequences of that inversion—for the metaphysics of the quintessence, for theodicy, and for the theology of incarnation—are the subject of this dissertation.

0.4 Method: *Nachleben*, Bricolage, Constellation

No claim is made here that Besson or Kamen read Empedocles, Bernard of Clairvaux, or Luce Irigaray. Three evidentiary registers are therefore distinguished throughout. The *documentary* register concerns what the production record establishes: the collaboration of Mœbius and Mézières, Gaultier's costume corpus, Serra's score, the adolescent manuscript, the unsuccessful plagiarism action brought by Alejandro Jodorowsky and the publisher Les Humanoïdes Associés over resemblances to *L'Incal*. The *intertextual* register concerns demonstrable allusion within the cinematic and graphic traditions the film openly cites: *Metropolis*, *Bride of Frankenstein*, Beineix's *Diva*, *Barbarella*, the *Valérian* albums. The *hermeneutic* register concerns structural homologies with philosophical and religious traditions; these are offered as illuminations, never as sources.

Three warrants license the third register. The first is Aby Warburg's doctrine of the *Nachleben der Antike*: the afterlife of ancient pathos-formulae, which migrate through images independently of the intentions of those who transmit them, so that a gesture of maenadic frenzy may reappear in a Florentine nymph or a modern advertisement. Warburg's *Mnemosyne* atlas (1924–1929) is the model for the constellational juxtapositions attempted here. The second is Claude Lévi-Strauss's methodological reversal in *Le Cru et le cuit* (1964): the analyst shows not how men think in myths but how myths think themselves in men, *et à leur insu*—without their knowledge. Its corollary, from *La Pensée sauvage* (1962), is decisive: the bricoleur works with pre-constrained elements, fragments that carry the residue of their prior uses and therefore import meanings their assembler need not intend. A blockbuster built from Egyptology, opera, the *bande dessinée*, and the action film is bricolage in the strict sense, and its fragments arrive freighted with their histories. The third warrant is Walter Benjamin's proposition, in the epistemo-critical prologue to the *Trauerspiel* book (1928), that ideas

stand to phenomena as constellations stand to stars: the idea is not extracted from any single datum but drawn between many.

The risks of such a method are well known. Jonathan Z. Smith (1982; 1990) taught a generation of comparativists that comparison is not discovery but a scholarly act, an interested exaggeration undertaken for the sake of a theoretical problem, and that the "morphologies" of Mircea Eliade too often dissolve history into archetype. The discipline adopted here answers Smith in two ways. Every comparison is anchored to a specific narrative or visual datum in the film, and every comparison is made to serve the single theoretical problem stated in 0.3: the passage from a substantial to a relational conception of the fifth. Fredric Jameson's (1991) diagnosis of postmodern pastiche as blank parody, emptied of the satiric impulse and the affect of its originals, is accepted as a description of the film's surface and rejected as a description of its operation, for reasons argued in Chapters VI and VII: few films of the decade are as saturated with affect at their core as this one is ironised at its periphery.

Thesis and Plan of the Work 0.5

The dissertation's central claim is that *The Fifth Element* enacts what it here terms **metaxic quintessentialism**: the doctrine that the fifth principle which binds and activates the four is not a further substance but an interval (*metaxu*), and that this interval is constituted by love. Four propositions articulate the claim. The *pemptic inversion* (from Greek *pemptos*, "fifth") relocates the quintessence from substance to relation. The *theurgic inversion* holds that the divine in this cosmos acts only when humanly loved, reversing the direction of incarnational salvation. The *osculatory theodicy* holds that the problem of evil, posed in the film with full Dostoevskian force, is answered not by argument but by a kiss. The *sociocosmic tetrasomia* holds that the four classical elements are redistributed across the four institutional powers of late modernity—state, industry, broadcasting, spectacle—none of which can administer the fifth. Two corollaries concern the film's carnivalesque tonality and the cosmogonic, rather than annihilating, fate of its Evil.

Part One reconstructs genealogies. Chapter I is an archaeology of the fifth from Empedocles to the Renaissance *spiritus mundi* and across the

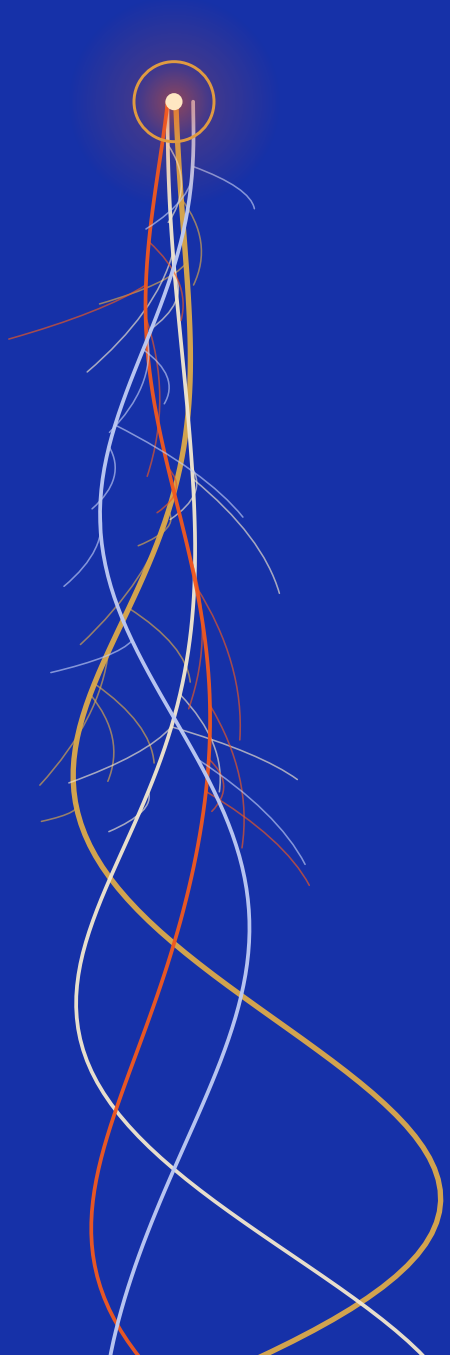
Indian, Japanese, Chinese, and Mesoamerican pentads, establishing a suppressed "medial" tradition of the quintessence. Chapter II reads the film's calendar of evil and its Egyptian temple through the comparative mythology of the chaos-combat. Chapter III reconstructs the French genealogy—esoteric, Revolutionary, philosophical, graphic, and cinematic—without which the film's theology is unintelligible.

Part Two anatomises the film's principal figures. Chapter IV treats the regeneration of Leeloo as a theology of the laboratory. Chapter V treats Zorg as the theodicist of breakage and the Evil as mimetic violence. Chapter VI treats Leeloo's reading of the archive as a restaging of the Fall and an interrogation of theodicy after Auschwitz. Chapter VII treats spectacle, carnival, camp, and gender, and formulates the sociocosmic tetrasomia.

Part Three widens and closes. Chapter VIII situates the film among cognate speculative, mythological, and philosophical works. Chapter IX states the original thesis in full. The Conclusion condenses it into numbered theses.

Part One

Genealogies





Chapter I

Pempton Sōma

An Archaeology of the Fifth

The history of the fifth element is the history of an undecided question: whether the principle that completes and unifies the four is a further *thing* or the *bond* between things. The Western tradition, from Aristotle's aether to the scholastic quintessence, largely answered the first way; but a minority lineage—Empedoclean, Platonic, Stoic, Renaissance-Hermetic—answered the second, and parallel traditions in India, Japan, China, and Mesoamerica distributed the same options differently. This chapter reconstructs both lineages, because *The Fifth Element* invokes the first in its title and enacts the second in its plot.

I.1 Empedocles: Four Roots, Two Forces, and the Geometry of "Among"

Empedocles of Akragas (c. 494–434 BCE) named four "roots" (*rhizōmata*)—fire, air, water, earth—and set over them two forces: Love (*Philotēs*, also called Aphrodite, Kypris, and Harmonia) and Strife (*Neikos*). The cosmos oscillates between the dominion of Love, under which the roots are fused into the perfect, motionless Sphere (*Sphairos*), and the dominion of Strife, under which they are wrenched apart; our world is a phase of transition (Inwood 2001). The roots are ungenerated and imperishable; what comes

to be and passes away are only their mixtures and separations. Birth and death, in Empedocles' striking formulation, are merely names that mortals give to mingling and unmingling.

The decisive text for this study is fragment B17, lines 18–20, which supplies the second epigraph. Empedocles places Strife *apart from* the roots (*dicha tōn*) and Love *among* them (*en toisin*). The prepositions are not ornamental. Strife is exterior, an agent that acts upon the elements from outside; Love is interior, a principle that exists only in the intervals between them, "equal in length and breadth" with the very mixtures it effects. Empedoclean Love is the first articulation in Western thought of a cosmic force that is not a fifth stuff but the medium of the four.

The final tableau of *The Fifth Element* reproduces this geometry with diagrammatic fidelity. Four stones stand at the cardinal points of the temple chamber; at their centre, *among* them, stand two persons who will become, for the duration of an embrace, a single radiant figure; and *apart from* them, approaching from deep space, comes a mass of undifferentiated malice that has already shattered a warship and that the film explicitly links to the human propensity for war. The Evil is Neikos: exterior, separative, nourished by division. What answers it is not an element but Philotēs in its original Empedoclean location—the between.

Two further Empedoclean features reinforce the homology. First, the alternation of Love and Strife is cyclical, and the film's Evil is likewise periodic, returning every five thousand years. Second, Peter Kingsley (1995) has argued that Empedocles was less a natural philosopher in the modern sense than a magus and healer within a Pythagorean-mystery tradition, for whom cosmology and soteriology were inseparable; the roots were also gods, and knowledge of them was a means of purification. The film's fusion of cosmological weapon and salvific act—its refusal to distinguish physics from redemption—is, in this light, more archaic than it is naive.

Plato's *Timaeus*: The Fifth as the Shape of the Whole and the Bond as the Most Beautiful Thing 1.2

Plato's *Timaeus* geometrises the Empedoclean roots. Fire is the tetrahedron, air the octahedron, water the icosahedron, earth the cube, each built from elementary triangles (53c–56c). A fifth regular solid, the dodec-

ahedron, remains; and Timaeus reports, with conspicuous reticence, that the god used this fifth construction "for the whole," embellishing it with figures (55c). The fifth is thus not a fifth element among elements but the *form of totality*—the shape of the cosmos considered as a unity. Already in Plato the fifth slides from the register of matter to the register of structure.

The point is confirmed by an earlier passage that is among the most consequential in ancient cosmology. Explaining why the world-body requires intermediate elements between fire and earth, Timaeus declares that of all bonds (*desmoi*) the most beautiful is that which makes itself and the things it binds as nearly one as possible, and that proportion (*analogia*) accomplishes this most perfectly (31c). Fire stands to air as air to water, and air to water as water to earth (32b). The unity of the cosmos is therefore secured not by any of its constituents but by a relation among them; and Plato calls that relation the most beautiful thing in the account. When *The Fifth Element* makes its four stones inert until bound by an act passing between two persons, it is rehearsing, in the idiom of the action film, the cosmology of the *desmos*.

The *Timaeus* adds one more motif that the film inherits. The Demiurge fashions the world because he is good, and the good bears no envy (29e). Creation is an overflow of benevolence. The Mondoshawans—custodians who return across centuries to protect a species that does not know they exist—are demiurgic in exactly this sense: they act from a goodness without envy, and they are rewarded by being shot down.

I.3 Aristotle: Aether, the "Fifth Nature" of Mind, and the God Who Moves by Being Loved

Aristotle hardened the fifth into a substance. In *De Caelo* I.2–3 he argues that because the natural motion of the four sublunary elements is rectilinear (fire and air up, water and earth down), the eternal circular motion of the heavens requires a further body, "the first body," neither heavy nor light, ungenerated, incorruptible, and unalterable. He derives its traditional name, *aithēr*, from *aei thein*, "always running" (270b22). The doxographic tradition renamed it the "fifth body" (*pempton sōma*), and the Latin West translated that as *quinta essentia*.

A second Aristotelian fifth survives only in report. Cicero, in the *Tusculan Disputations* (I.22), attributes to Aristotle a "fifth kind" without a name, from which mind is made, and records that Aristotle called the soul by a new term, *endelecheia*, signifying a continuous and perpetual motion. The fifth is here no longer the stuff of the stars but the stuff of mind. When the scientists in *The Fifth Element* discover that their reconstituted being carries informational resources beyond any human genome, they are, without knowing it, rediscovering the Ciceronian Aristotle: the quintessence as the substrate of intelligence.

The third Aristotelian text is the one the film most precisely inverts. In *Metaphysics* Λ.7 the unmoved mover causes motion "as being loved" (*kinei hōs erōmenon*, 1072b3): it moves the heavens not by pushing but by being the object of their desire, while itself remaining unmoved. In Besson and Kamen's cosmos the order is reversed. The divine principle does not move the world by being loved; it is itself moved—from despair to action, from inertia to radiance—by being loved. Aristotle's active *kinei* becomes a passive *kineitai*. The God of the philosophers, who loves nothing and is loved by everything, becomes a god who cannot act until a cab driver tells her he loves her. That grammatical shift is the hinge of the theurgic inversion developed in Chapter IX.

Stoic Pneuma and the Cosmology of Sympathy I.4

The Stoics dissolved Aristotle's separation between sublunary and celestial matter. For Chrysippus the cosmos is held together by *pneuma*, a blend of fire and air whose "tensile motion" (*tonikē kinēsis*) gives every body its cohesion and binds every part of the universe into a single sympathetic whole (*sympatheia*). Pneuma is a substance, but a substance whose entire function is relational: it exists to bind. The Stoic universe is a tissue of correspondences in which an event in one region resonates in all others. *The Fifth Element* is Stoic in its cosmic politics: a war in the twentieth century is causally continuous with an evil in deep space; the ingestion of an encyclopedia on a computer screen in New York is continuous with the fate of the planet. Nothing is local.

1.5 The Medial Quintessence: Ficino and Agrippa

The Renaissance recovery of Neoplatonism and the *Corpus Hermeticum*—translated by Marsilio Ficino from 1463 and printed in 1471—produced the most explicit formulation of the fifth as a between. In *De vita libri tres* (1489), Book III, Ficino argues that the soul of the world cannot act directly upon the body of the world; there must be a *spiritus mundi*, a world-spirit, interposed between them, and this spirit is the quintessence through which celestial influence descends into matter. Heinrich Cornelius Agrippa, in *De occulta philosophia* (1533), Book I, chapter 14, systematises the doctrine: the spirit of the world is called the quintessence because it is not composed of the four elements but is a certain fifth thing above and beside them, and its office is to be the *medium* by which celestial souls are joined to gross bodies.

This medial quintessence is the suppressed lineage that *The Fifth Element* reactivates. In Ficino and Agrippa the fifth is defined not by what it is made of but by what it does: it mediates. It is neither soul nor body but the commerce between them; neither heaven nor earth but the traffic that joins them. The film's narrative performs exactly this redefinition. Leeloo, considered as a substance, is the quintessence of the Aristotelian kind—incorruptible, perfect, informationally plenary. Leeloo considered as an agent is the quintessence of the Ficinian kind, and she becomes an agent only when the interval between her and a human being is filled.

It is no accident that the film's priest bears the name Cornelius. The coincidence with Heinrich Cornelius Agrippa need not be intended to be instructive: the guardian of the fifth element shares a name with the Renaissance philosopher who defined the fifth element as a medium.

1.6 The Apocalyptic Quintessence: John of Rupescissa

The most startling precedent for the film's structure lies in the fourteenth century. John of Rupescissa (Jean de Roquetaillade, c. 1310–c. 1366), a Franciscan of the Spiritual tendency imprisoned at Avignon for his prophecies, composed in about 1351–1352 the treatise *De consideratione quintae essentiae*, the founding text of medical alchemy. Rupescissa taught that by repeated distillation of *aqua ardens* one could obtain a terrestrial analogue of the incorruptible heavens—a substance he called "our heaven"

(*caelum nostrum*)—capable of preserving the human body from corruption. Leah DeVun (2009) has shown that this programme was inseparable from Rupescissa's apocalypticism: he expected the imminent arrival of Antichrist and intended the quintessence to sustain the evangelical poor through the tribulations of the end.

The structural homology with the film is close enough to be uncanny. A religious order anticipates the coming of a cosmic adversary; it guards a quintessential secret; the quintessence is a technology of preservation against corruption; and its deployment is calibrated to an apocalyptic calendar. Rupescissa's quintessence was meant to keep life alive through the end of time. The Mondoshawan's dictum—that time does not matter and only life does—is the motto his treatise never had.

The Pentads of the World I.7

Outside the Greek and Latin lineages, five-fold cosmologies distribute the options differently, and their differences sharpen the film's choice.

Three of these call for comment. In the *Taittirīya Upaniṣad* (2.1) the series runs in emanative order: from the self (*ātman*) arises space (*ākāśa*); from space, air; from air, fire; from fire, water; from water, earth. The "fifth" is in truth the first, the subtlest and most originary, from which the four descend. Leeloo, the last to be assembled, is in this sense the first in being: her regeneration is a recapitulation of an emanation that preceded the elements she completes.

The Japanese *godai*, familiar in the West through the five books of Miyamoto Musashi's *Go Rin no Sho* (1645) and the five-tiered *gorintō* stupa, culminates in *kū*, emptiness. In the Madhyamaka philosophy that underwrites East Asian Buddhist usage, emptiness is not a void substance but the absence of self-standing essence; Nāgārjuna's *Mūlamadhyamakakārikā* (24.18) identifies it with dependent origination (*pratītyasamutpāda*). The fifth, in this tradition, is relationality itself—the doctrine that nothing exists except in and through its relations. This is the most radical precedent for the pemptic inversion, and it arrives from the tradition that also shaped the Okinawan and Japanese martial philosophies on which Kamen had drawn for *The Karate Kid*.

The Pentads of the World



Tradition

Empedocles (5th c. BCE)

The four (or the series)

fire, air, water, earth

The fifth

Love and Strife as forces

Status of the fifth

Relational: Love dwells "among" the roots

Resonance in the film

The couple among the stones; Evil as exterior Strife



Tradition

Plato, *Timaeus*

The four (or the series)

tetrahedron, octahedron, icosahedron, cube

The fifth

dodecahedron, "for the whole"

Status of the fifth

Structural: the form of totality; unity secured by the *desmos*

Resonance in the film

The weapon works only as a bound configuration



Tradition

Aristotle, *De Caelo*

The four (or the series)

the four sublunary elements

The fifth

aether, the "first body"

Status of the fifth

Substantial: incorruptible celestial matter

Resonance in the film

The title's promise; the "perfect" body



Tradition

Ficino and Agrippa

The four (or the series)

the four elements

The fifth

spiritus mundi, the quintessence

Status of the fifth

Medial: the go-between of world-soul and world-body

Resonance in the film

Leeloo as agent only through relation



Tradition

Upaniṣadic and Sāṃkhya *pañcamahābhūta*

The four (or the series)

earth, water, fire, air

The fifth

ākāśa (space, ether)

Status of the fifth

Originary: first emanated from the self

Resonance in the film

The fifth as source, not supplement



Tradition

Japanese *godai* (Musashi, *gorintō*)

The four (or the series)

chi, *sui*, *ka*, *fū*

The fifth

kū, the void

Status of the fifth

Emptiness, which Madhyamaka equates with dependent origination

Resonance in the film

The fifth as pure relationality



Tradition

Chinese *wuxing*

The four (or the series)

wood, fire, earth, metal, water

The fifth

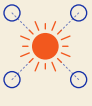
none: five phases in cycles

Status of the fifth

Wholly relational: generation (*shēng*) and overcoming (*kè*)

Resonance in the film

Zorg's destruction misread as a cycle without balance



Tradition

Mexica Legend of the Suns

The four (or the series)

jaguar, wind, fire-rain, flood

The fifth

the Fifth Sun, *Nahui Ollin* ("4 Movement")

Status of the fifth

An age born of self-sacrifice

Resonance in the film

The present age saved by an act, not a thing

Tibetan Buddhism and Bön preserve a fivefold scheme in which earth, water, fire, air, and space each possess a pure essence that appears as one of five lights. In the Dzogchen traditions the death of a fully realised practitioner may issue in the "rainbow body" (*'ja' lus*), the dissolution of the physical body into those five lights. Leeloo's body at the climax, radiating a light that gathers the elements set around her, belongs to this image—with the difference that her transfiguration is not the reward of solitary realisation but the effect of a relation.

The Chinese *wuxing* is not a theory of elements at all but of phases (*xing*, "movements"), defined entirely by their mutual generation and mutual overcoming. Destruction belongs to the system—water overcomes fire, metal overcomes wood—but only within a balance that it serves. Zorg, as Chapter V shows, will mistake the overcoming cycle for the whole of cosmology.

Finally, the Mexica cosmogony recorded in the *Leyenda de los Soles* (1558) and the *Florentine Codex* describes four prior worlds, or Suns, each destroyed by an elemental catastrophe, and a Fifth Sun, our own, born at Teotihuacán when the humble, sore-covered god Nanahuatzin leapt into the sacred fire after the splendid Tecuciztecatl hesitated. The fifth age exists because of a leap. Chapter II returns to this cosmogony and to the New Fire ceremony that renewed it.

Conclusion: Two Lineages and a Title I.8

The archaeology yields two lineages. The *substantial* lineage—Aristotelian aether, scholastic quintessence, the subtle *ākāśa* considered as stuff—treats the fifth as a further and finer thing. The *medial* lineage—Empedoclean Love among the roots, Plato's most beautiful bond, Stoic sympathy, Ficino's and Agrippa's world-spirit, Madhyamaka emptiness, the cycles of *wuxing*—treats the fifth as the relation by which the others hold together. The title of Besson and Kamen's film is drawn from the first lineage. Its plot belongs entirely to the second. The remainder of this dissertation follows the plot.



Chapter II

Cosmogram and Calendar

Chaoskampf, Cyclical Evil, and the Temple as a Machine against Chaos

The Fifth Element possesses a calendar before it possesses a plot. An Evil returns every five thousand years; a temple in Egypt houses the only instrument that can repel it; custodians depart on the eve of a world war and promise to return. These three data—periodicity, ritual technology, divine withdrawal and return—locate the film within the oldest narrative of the ancient Near East and its cognates: the combat of a god of order against the monster of chaos, re-enacted at regular intervals to renew the world. This chapter reads the film as a *cosmogram*, a diagram of the cosmos in narrative form, and argues that it rejects the linear eschatology of Zoroastrian and Christian apocalyptic in favour of an older, cyclical model in which chaos is never abolished but only, and always provisionally, transformed.

II.1 Egypt: Apophis, Ma'at, and the Temple of the Whole World

In Egyptian cosmology the sun-god Ra crosses the sky by day and the underworld by night in his barque, and each night the serpent Apophis (Apep), embodiment of *isfet*—disorder, falsehood, unbeing—attempts to swallow him. The cosmos survives because Apophis is defeated nightly, and it is defeated not only by the gods but by the priests. The ritual texts gathered in the *Book of Overthrowing Apophis*, preserved in the

Papyrus Bremner-Rhind, prescribe the fashioning, binding, spitting upon, trampling, and burning of effigies of the serpent: liturgy as cosmic defence. Order (*ma'at*) is not a given state of affairs but a condition continuously produced by right action, and the temple is the machine that produces it.

The Egyptian temple of *The Fifth Element* is an anti-Apophis machine in this precise sense. Its inscriptions encode a weapon; its chamber is calibrated to a celestial alignment; its operation requires a priest, a liturgical sequence, and the presence of the elements. What the film adds to the Egyptian model is the identity of the adversary. Apophis is not merely darkness; he is the active negation of creation, and he cannot be destroyed, only repelled, because he belongs to the precreated waters from which the world emerged. The Great Evil of the film is likewise an anti-cosmos: a mass of darkness wrapped in fire that speaks, through its servant Zorg, the language of unmaking, and that the film's ending will neutralise without annihilating.

Jan Assmann's reconstruction of *ma'at* (1990) adds a decisive refinement. Ma'at, he argues, is not abstract cosmic order but *connective justice* (*konnektive Gerechtigkeit*): the principle by which human beings act for one another, remember one another, and answer for one another, so that social solidarity and cosmic order are the same fabric seen at two scales. For Assmann, Egyptian order is constitutively relational—the opposite of *isfet* is not light but connection. The film's Egyptian temple thus houses not merely a weapon but a doctrine: chaos is defeated by connection. When the instrument finally fires, it does so because two persons have connected. The temple's theology anticipates the plot's resolution.

The choice of Egypt has a further, Hermetic overdetermination. In the Latin *Asclepius* (chapters 24–26), Hermes Trismegistus calls Egypt the image of heaven and the temple of the whole world, then prophesies a time when the gods will withdraw from the earth, Egypt will be abandoned, and impiety and violence will rule, until the creator restores the world to its ancient beauty. The Mondoshawans' departure in 1914 and return in the twenty-third century reproduce this Hermetic apocalypse almost point for point: withdrawal of the divine, an age of violence, restoration. That the Western imagination of a sacred, prophetic Egypt is itself largely a Hellenistic and European construction—the subject of Erik Hornung's *Das esoterische Ägypten* (1999) and of Frances Yates's (1964) history of

Renaissance Hermeticism—does not weaken the homology. It explains it. The film's Egypt is the Egypt of the *Asclepius*, of Napoleon's *Description de l'Égypte*, and of Champollion's decipherment of 1822; its archaeologist reading a prophecy in hieroglyphs is the emblem of a European modernity that sought its future in an Orientalised past (Said 1978).

The date of the prologue sharpens the point. On 18 December 1914 Britain declared Egypt a protectorate. The Egyptian Antiquities Service had been directed by Frenchmen since Auguste Mariette's appointment in 1858, and under the *partage* system foreign excavators exported a large share of their finds to museums in Europe and North America. The Mondoshawans arrive in that year to remove Egypt's most sacred objects for safekeeping, on the ground that the country is about to become too dangerous to hold them. Their benevolence is the self-justification of colonial custodianship, restaged with extraterrestrials in the role of the European museum. The ancient-astronaut literature on which the film draws (Chapter III) adds a second erasure: by attributing the monuments of Egypt and of other non-European civilisations to visitors from elsewhere, it denies their builders the achievement, an implication archaeologists have criticised as racist (Feder 1990). The film inherits both gestures. Its temple is Egyptian; its custodians are extraterrestrial and its archaeologists Western.

II.2 Gunkel's Law: The End Repeats the Beginning

Hermann Gunkel's *Schöpfung und Chaos in Urzeit und Endzeit* (1895) established the comparative study of the chaos-combat (*Chaoskampf*). Its subtitle announces its two texts: Genesis 1 and Revelation 12. Gunkel argued that the Babylonian combat of Marduk against Tiamat survives, demythologised, in the separation of the waters in Genesis, and returns, remythologised, in the dragon of the Apocalypse; and he formulated the principle that has governed the study of eschatology since: the end-time repeats the primordial time (*Endzeit gleich Urzeit*). The last battle is the first battle fought again.

In the *Enūma Eliš*, Tiamat, the salt-water mother of the gods, raises an army of monsters against the younger deities. Marduk, armed with the winds, drives the evil wind into her open mouth so that she cannot close it, shoots an arrow into her distended belly, and splits her body in two like

a dried fish, setting one half above as the sky and the other below as the foundation of the earth. Chaos is not abolished; it becomes the material of cosmos. The poem was recited during the Babylonian New Year festival (*Akītu*), which ritually renewed the world each year.

The ending of *The Fifth Element* is an *Enūma Eliš* in miniature. The Evil is not shattered, dispersed, or expelled; struck by the light, it cools, darkens, and remains in Earth's sky as an inert planetoid—a new celestial body added to the cosmos. Like Tiamat's corpse, the defeated adversary becomes part of the furniture of heaven. And in the film's visual vocabulary the result recalls with precision the text Gunkel paired with Genesis. Revelation 12 shows "a woman clothed with the sun, and the moon under her feet," while a great red dragon waits to devour her child and war breaks out in heaven. Leeloo, clothed in light at the climax, leaves behind her a dead moon. The iconography of the *Mulier amicta sole*, transmitted to Western art through the Immaculata tradition in which the Virgin stands upon the crescent and crushes the serpent—a tradition nourished by the Vulgate's feminine reading of Genesis 3:15, *ipsa conteret caput tuum*—finds an unlikely heir in a blockbuster's final shot.

The biblical corpus multiplies the motif. Psalm 74 praises the God who broke the heads of the dragons in the waters and crushed Leviathan; Isaiah 27:1 promises that on the last day the Lord will punish Leviathan the twisting serpent; Job 41 makes the monster an object of divine pride. In each case the dragon is not merely an enemy but a constituent of creation, mastered and placed rather than erased. The film's Evil belongs to this lineage of monsters that the cosmos absorbs.

Zoroastrian Time and the Saviour from Preserved Seed II.3

Norman Cohn (1993) argued that Zoroaster transformed the cyclical combat myth into a linear eschatology: in the Iranian scheme preserved in the Pahlavi *Bundahišn*, world history lasts twelve thousand years, divided into four periods of three thousand, culminating not in a renewed cycle but in a final renovation (*frashokereti*) in which Ahriman is defeated forever, the dead are raised, and the world is made wonderful. Cohn traced from this Iranian innovation the apocalyptic faiths of Judaism and Christianity.

Two features of the Zoroastrian scheme bear directly on the film. The first is its saviours. Zarathustra's seed, according to the tradition, is preserved in Lake Kąsaoya, guarded by 99,999 *fravashis*; at intervals of a thousand years, three virgins bathing in the lake conceive three posthumous sons of the prophet, the last of whom, Astvat-ereta, the Saoshyant, accomplishes the renovation. The saviour is thus reconstituted from preserved germinal material across millennia under spiritual guardianship. Leeloo—regenerated from a cell preserved inside a gloved hand, the remnant of a sarcophagus guarded for centuries by armoured custodians—is a Saoshyant of the laboratory. The second feature is quaternary periodisation: four ages, then the end. The film's four stones and fifth figure echo this arithmetic of completion.

Yet the film declines the Zoroastrian conclusion. Its Evil returns every five thousand years; its defeat is a pause, not an abolition. In Cohn's terms, *The Fifth Element* is pre-Zoroastrian: it restores the cyclical cosmology that apocalyptic faith overcame. This is not a regression but a theological position, developed in Chapter IX as the corollary of cosmogonic non-annihilation: a cosmos in which salvation is periodic must be loved again in every age.

II.4 The *Avatāra* and the Arithmetic of Ages

The Sanskrit *avatāra* derives from *ava-√tṛ*, "to cross down," "to descend." In the *Bhagavad Gītā* (4.7–8), Krishna declares that whenever righteousness (*dharma*) declines and unrighteousness rises, he sends himself forth; for the protection of the good, the destruction of evildoers, and the establishment of dharma, he comes into being age after age (*sambhavāmi yuge yuge*). The doctrine combines periodicity with descent: the divine enters the world repeatedly, at the moments of greatest disorder, in a body.

Leeloo's descent is staged with almost catechetical literalness. Having escaped the laboratory, she stands on a ledge high above the city and steps off; the camera follows her fall through stratum after stratum of airborne traffic until she crashes through the roof of a taxi. The vertical megacity becomes a cosmology of levels—*lokas* stacked between heaven and the polluted ground—and the avatar crosses them downward. The taxi is her

vāhana, the mount on which deities ride, as Garuḍa bears Viṣṇu; its driver will become, as Chapter IX argues, something more than a vehicle.

The arithmetic of ages offers a further, esoteric resonance. Traditional Indian reckoning dates the beginning of the Kali Yuga, the darkest of the four ages, to 3102 BCE. Theosophical writers following Helena Blavatsky made much of the claim that the first five-thousand-year cycle of the Kali Yuga closed in the late 1890s, inaugurating a new spiritual epoch; the motif passed into the wider occult imagination of the twentieth century. Whether or not the film's five-thousand-year Evil descends from this reckoning, it shares its form: an age of darkness measured in five-millennium units, and a turning point placed at the threshold of the twentieth century. The Mondoshawans arrive in 1914.

The Fifth Sun and the New Fire II.5

The Mexica cosmogony describes a series of Suns, each an age of the world destroyed by an elemental catastrophe: jaguars, wind, a rain of fire, flood. The present age is the Fifth Sun, *Nahui Ollin*, "4 Movement," destined to end in earthquakes. According to the account in Book 7 of the *Florentine Codex*, the gods assembled in darkness at Teotihuacán to decide who would become the new sun. The splendid Tecuciztecatl volunteered but four times recoiled from the sacrificial fire; the humble, sore-covered Nanahuatzin leapt without hesitation and rose as the sun. The Fifth Sun exists because the least of the gods leapt.

The Mexica preserved the Fifth Sun through the *Xiuhmolpilli*, the Binding of the Years, performed at the completion of each fifty-two-year cycle. All fires in the land were extinguished; at midnight, on the Hill of the Star (Huixachtlan), priests killed a war captive, kindling the new fire on his chest and casting his heart into the flame; had the fire failed to kindle, it was believed, the sun would not rise and the star-demons (*tzitzimimeh*) would descend to devour humankind. When the flame caught, it was carried to every hearth.

The climactic temple sequence of *The Fifth Element* is a New Fire ceremony. The world's survival depends on a kindling at the exact moment; the threat is a descending darkness; and the kindling is entrusted to the humblest of the participants. Korben, who has been trying to give up

smoking in a society that sells cigarettes consisting almost wholly of filter—a regime of hygienic administration that has, so to speak, extinguished fire—has kept one match. He strikes it to open the stone of fire. The scene is also Promethean: in Hesiod (*Theogony* 565–567; *Works and Days* 50–52) Prometheus smuggles fire to mortals hidden in a fennel stalk, and Korben's matchbox is the *narthēx* of a sanitised civilisation. But where the Mexica rite required a heart and the Promethean myth required a theft, the film's rite requires sweat, breath, sand, a last match, and a declaration. Sacrifice is sublimated into bodily offering and eros—with one remainder, the Diva, whose death is examined in Chapter VII.

II.6 Eliade and the Terror of History

Mircea Eliade's *Le Mythe de l'éternel retour* (1949) argued that archaic societies defended themselves against the meaninglessness of events by abolishing profane time through the ritual repetition of cosmogonic archetypes: the New Year re-enacts creation, and history is periodically annulled. Its final chapter, "The Terror of History," asks how modern human beings, having renounced archetype for linear history, can endure the catastrophes that history inflicts without consolation. Eliade's examples are the deportations and massacres of his century and the atomic bomb.

The Fifth Element is structured as a response to Eliade's question. Its prologue is set in 1914, the year in which Eric Hobsbawm (1994) began his "short twentieth century," and the Mondoshawans remove the elements because the war about to begin makes Earth unsafe. The gods withdraw precisely when history becomes terrible—a narrative figure for what Martin Buber (1952) called the eclipse of God. The film's cosmogony then re-mythologises that history, converting the twentieth century into a phase of a cosmic cycle with a known adversary and a guaranteed remedy. But it also, through Leeloo's reading of the archive (Chapter VI), re-exposes the divine itself to the terror of history. The film does not choose between archetype and history. It makes the archetype read history, and nearly die of it.

Eliade's own history bears on the reading. In 1937 and 1938 he published articles supporting the Legion of the Archangel Michael, the Romanian fascist movement also known as the Iron Guard. Its members assassinated the prime ministers Ion Duca in 1933 and Armand Călinescu

in 1939, and during the Legionnaires' rebellion of January 1941 they carried out a pogrom in Bucharest that killed about 125 Jews. Critics have read Eliade's later prescription of an escape from the terror of history into archetype in light of that record (Wasserstrom 1999). The point for the present argument is precise: an archetypal consolation that annuls history can also annul responsibility for it. The film's double movement, which re-mythologises the century and then makes its god read the century's record, is the more defensible of the two options Eliade's book sets out, because it does not let the archetype absolve the archive.

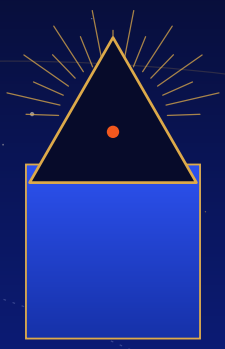
"Time Not Important": Boethius, Bergson, Kermode II.7

The Mondoshawan's dictum, spoken across a promised absence of centuries, is the theological key to the film's calendar. It subordinates *chronos* to *zōē*. Its most exact antecedent is Boethius, whose *Consolation of Philosophy* (V.6) defines eternity not as endless duration but as "the complete, simultaneous, and perfect possession of interminable life" (*interminabilis vitae tota simul et perfecta possessio*). Eternity, for Boethius, is a mode of *life*, not of time. The Mondoshawans, who measure their obligations in centuries and indifferently, are Boethian beings: they live in the *tota simul*.

Henri Bergson's *Essai sur les données immédiates de la conscience* (1889) distinguished spatialised, measurable time from *durée*, the qualitative, interpenetrating time of lived experience. The film's climax sets them against each other. A countdown—homogeneous, numerical, the clock of the Bulletin of the Atomic Scientists translated into a plot device—ticks toward impact; and the decisive act occurs in a moment that the countdown cannot measure, because it is not a quantity but a quality. Frank Kermode (1967) called such moments *kairoi*: seasons charged with significance by their relation to an end, as opposed to the merely successive *chronos*. The kiss is the film's *kairos*. The countdown is the form of the Evil's time; the kiss is the form of life's.

The cosmogram is therefore complete. The film inherits from Egypt a temple that maintains order through connection; from Babylon a monster whose defeat becomes cosmos; from Iran a saviour reconstituted from preserved seed; from India a periodic descent; from Mexico a world renewed by a single fire kindled at the brink; and from Boethius a doctrine that

ranks life above time. What it adds is the identity of the force that turns the machine. That force is examined in Part Two and named in Chapter IX.



Chapter III

Réalisme fantastique and the *Être suprême*

The French Genealogy of a Euro-American Myth

THE COSMOLOGY RECONSTRUCTED in Chapters I and II is pan-human; the theology of *The Fifth Element* is French. Its Supreme Being is named in the vocabulary of the Revolution; its Egyptian secret descends from a specifically French esoteric publishing culture; its imagery is drawn from the Franco-Belgian *bande dessinée*; its aesthetic was formed in the polemics of the *cinéma du look*; its love-metaphysics has precedents in Bergson, Teilhard, and Breton; and its industrial form answers the cultural politics of the *exception culturelle*. This chapter reconstructs that genealogy, distinguishing throughout between documented transmission and structural affinity.

Réalisme fantastique: Pauwels, Bergier, and the Planetary Sixties III.1

In 1960 Louis Pauwels and Jacques Bergier published *Le Matin des magiciens*, a vast, digressive bestseller that proposed a "fantastic realism" (*réalisme fantastique*): the conviction that the real is stranger than rationalism admits, that ancient civilisations possessed lost technologies, that secret societies have transmitted hidden knowledge across millennia, that alchemy was a science, and that the occult currents of the twentieth century —including those of National Socialism—demanded serious attention.

The magazine *Planète* (1961–1971) carried the programme to a mass readership. Robert Charroux's *Histoire inconnue des hommes depuis cent mille ans* (1963) and, in German, Erich von Däniken's *Erinnerungen an die Zukunft* (1968) popularised its most durable progeny, the ancient-astronaut hypothesis, whose American ancestor was Charles Fort's *Book of the Damned* (1919).

Besson was born in 1959; the culture *Planète* created was the ambient mythology of his childhood. The prologue of *The Fifth Element* is fantastic realism distilled: an archaeologist in an Egyptian temple, a prophecy encoded in hieroglyphs, extraterrestrial custodians who built or used the site, a priestly order transmitting the secret across generations, and an imminent cosmic threat legible only to initiates. The comparison with the American variant is instructive. Steven Spielberg's *Raiders of the Lost Ark* (1981), set in Egypt in 1936, treats the hidden sacred object as a weapon that destroys those who misuse it; Roland Emmerich's *Stargate* (1994) treats the Egyptian gods as alien parasites to be unmasked and overthrown. Besson's film is closer to Pauwels and Bergier than to either: its aliens are neither tyrants nor tricksters but benevolent stewards, and its secret is not a power to be seized but a relation to be completed.

The genealogy has a political history that the film does not carry but its sources do. *Le Matin des magiciens* gave wide currency to the claim that National Socialism had an occult core transmitted through secret societies such as the Thule Society; Nicholas Goodrick-Clarke's *The Occult Roots of Nazism* (1985) showed that the claim rested largely on post-war myth-making, and such myths later fed neo-Nazi esotericism. Pauwels himself moved to the right and, as editor of *Le Figaro Magazine* from 1978, gave a platform to the French New Right. The ancient-astronaut hypothesis, for its part, has been criticised by archaeologists for attributing the monuments of Egypt, Mesoamerica, and other non-European civilisations to extraterrestrial visitors rather than to the peoples who built them (Feder 1990; see Chapter II.1). To situate the film in this lineage is not to endorse the lineage. It is to identify the materials the film recombines, including those whose implications it does not examine.

The Occult Revival: Lévi, Fulcanelli, Guénon, and the Tarot III.2

Behind *Planète* stood a century of French occultism. Éliphas Lévi's *Dogme et rituel de la haute magie* (1854–1856) fixed the modern meaning of the pentagram: upright, the spirit dominating the four elements and the microcosmic human being in harmony; inverted, matter dominating spirit and the emblem of evil. In the occult geometry Lévi bequeathed to the Hermetic Order of the Golden Dawn and its successors, the fifth point is spirit, presiding over earth, water, air, and fire. The diagram of the film's weapon is a pentagram unrolled into a temple floor.

The pseudonymous Fulcanelli's *Le Mystère des cathédrales* (1926) read the sculptural programmes of Notre-Dame and other Gothic churches as alchemical treatises in stone. Its method—the sacred building as a cipher for the Great Work, legible only to the initiate—is the method of the film's archaeologist, who reads in the temple walls the operating instructions for a cosmic apparatus. René Guénon, the founder of Traditionalism, contributed the darker frame. In *Le Règne de la quantité et les signes des temps* (1945) he described the modern world as the terminal phase of a cosmic cycle, a regime of pure quantity in which quality, hierarchy, and spirit dissolve; its end would be heralded by a "counter-initiation" and a "great parody" of the sacred. The New York of *The Fifth Element*—a city of numbered levels, licence points, automated police checks, cigarettes that are almost entirely filter, and a fast-food restaurant that flies—is a comic Guénonian reign of quantity, and Zorg, who sells a cosmic adversary the means to annihilate life, is its counter-initiate.

The Tarot, revived as an esoteric system in the French tradition from Antoine Court de Gébelin (1781) to Papus's *Le Tarot des Bohémiens* (1889), supplies the final iconographic key. The twenty-first major arcanum, *Le Monde*, shows a single figure within an oval wreath, the four living creatures of Ezekiel (1:10) and Revelation (4:7)—man, lion, ox, eagle—at its corners. Occultists from Lévi onward correlated the four creatures with the four elements; the medieval form of the same composition is the *Maiestas Domini*, Christ enthroned in a mandorla among the evangelists' symbols, carved on the tympana of Moissac and Chartres. Leeloo at the centre of the four stones, enveloped in radiance, is the World card animated: the fifth enthroned amid the four.

III.3 Philosophers of Cosmic Love: Bergson and Teilhard

Henri Bergson's *Les Deux Sources de la morale et de la religion* (1932) distinguished the "closed" morality of social obligation, which binds a group against its outsiders, from the "open" morality of the mystic, whose love extends to humanity as such and continues the creative impulse of life itself. Static religion defends society against the dissolving effects of intelligence; dynamic religion, which Bergson located supremely in Christian mysticism, is the *élan vital* become love. The book ends with a sentence whose literal realisation is the subject of Chapter IV: humanity must decide whether it wishes to go on living and to accomplish the essential function of the universe, which is *une machine à faire des dieux*—a machine for the making of gods.

Pierre Teilhard de Chardin, Jesuit priest and palaeontologist who worked on the Zhoukoudian excavations of *Sinanthropus*, extended Bergson's vitalism into a cosmic Christology. In *Le Phénomène humain* (published posthumously in 1955) evolution converges, through the thickening of consciousness into a planetary "noosphere," toward an Omega Point identified with the cosmic Christ; the energy of that convergence is love, which Teilhard treated as a physical as well as spiritual force, the "amorisation" of the universe. In a 1934 essay on the evolution of chastity he wrote that, having mastered winds, waves, tides, and gravity, humankind would one day harness for God *the energies of love*, and would then, for the second time in history, have discovered fire. The sentence enumerates the elements—air, water, the tidal and gravitational forces of earth—and then names love as a second fire beyond them. It is the most exact verbal anticipation of the film's cosmology in the French philosophical canon. Teilhard's vogue in France during the 1950s and 1960s, undiminished by the Holy Office's *monitum* of 1962, ensured that the idea of love as cosmic energy circulated far beyond theology. Father Cornelius, the priest-archaeologist who guards a cosmic secret and believes in a Supreme Being who arrives from the stars, is a Teilhardian type.

III.4 The *Être suprême*: Revolutionary Deism and Its Correction

In English, "Supreme Being" is a generic theism. In French, *l'Être suprême* is a proper name with a date. Rousseau's Savoyard Vicar (*Émile*, 1762) pro-

fessed a natural religion of conscience; the *Contrat social* (IV.8) prescribed a civil religion with a few positive dogmas, the first being the existence of a powerful, intelligent, beneficent Divinity. The Declaration of the Rights of Man and of the Citizen (1789) proclaimed its articles "in the presence and under the auspices of the Supreme Being." By the decree of 18 Floréal Year II—7 May 1794—the Convention, at Robespierre's urging, declared that the French people recognised the existence of the Supreme Being and the immortality of the soul. On 20 Prairial (8 June 1794), in the Festival of the Supreme Being choreographed by Jacques-Louis David, Robespierre set fire to an effigy of Atheism, from whose ashes a statue of Wisdom emerged—according to contemporary accounts, blackened by the smoke. Seven weeks later, on 10 Thermidor, Robespierre went to the guillotine.

The calendrical coincidence deserves record, if not weight: *The Fifth Element* opened Cannes on 7 May 1997, the two hundred and third anniversary of the decree that made the Supreme Being a constitutional fact. The substantive point is theological. The Revolutionary Supreme Being was a deity of reason and virtue without incarnation and without love—a guarantor of civic morality whose festival of 20 Prairial was followed two days later by the Law of 22 Prairial (10 June 1794). Drafted by Georges Couthon with Robespierre's support, the law abolished defence counsel before the Revolutionary Tribunal, allowed it to dispense with witnesses, and left it a single penalty, death; in the seven weeks before Thermidor nearly 1,400 people were guillotined in Paris, and over the whole Terror the revolutionary courts handed down some 17,000 death sentences across France (Greer 1935), while many thousands more died in prison or in summary killings. In his speech on the principles of political morality (17 Pluviôse Year II, 5 February 1794), Robespierre defined revolutionary government by a pairing: virtue, without which terror is baneful, and terror, *sans laquelle la vertu est impuissante*—without which virtue is powerless.

The Fifth Element rewrites Robespierre's formula. Its Supreme Being is likewise powerless on her own; but what supplies her power is not terror but love. The film's armies, which would impose order by force, merely enlarge the Evil; its Supreme Being, the incarnate abstraction of the Revolution, acts only when addressed in the second person by a single human being. Where Robespierre joined virtue to terror, the film joins being to love. It thus corrects the Revolutionary civil religion in a characteristically

French way—by importing into the deist abstraction the Catholic doctrine of incarnation and the Romantic doctrine of eros, and by relocating political theology from the festival to the couple.

III.5 The Graphic Genealogy: From *Barbarella* to *L'Incal*

The *bande dessinée*, which Claude Beylie christened the "ninth art" in 1964, is the documented visual source of the film. Jean-Claude Forest's *Barbarella* (serialised in *V Magazine* from 1962; filmed by Roger Vadim in 1968) established the template of the erotic, innocent female cosmic heroine whose goodness is itself a weapon; Chapter VIII examines its astonishing structural parallels. In December 1974 Mœbius, Philippe Druillet, Jean-Pierre Dionnet, and Bernard Farkas founded Les Humanoïdes Associés, whose magazine *Métal hurlant* (1975–1987) transformed the medium into a laboratory of mystical, erotic, and dystopian science fiction. Mœbius's *Arzach* (1975) and *Le Garage hermétique* (1976–1979), Druillet's cathedral-cosmic *Lone Sloane*, and the dispersal of Alejandro Jodorowsky's abortive *Dune* project of the mid-1970s, whose designers went on to shape *Alien* (1979), together created the visual idiom from which Besson drew.

L'Incal (1980–1988), written by Jodorowsky and drawn by Mœbius, is the closest single analogue. Its hero, John Difool, a shabby private detective, lives in a vertical city whose depths are a lethal shaft; the story opens with him falling down it. A luminous pyramid of cosmic consciousness, the Incal, must be protected from a universal Darkness; techno-priests, androgynous saviours, and a cyclical ending in which the narrative returns to its beginning complete a work saturated with Tarot, Kabbalah, and alchemy. Jodorowsky and the publisher sued Besson for plagiarism; the French courts dismissed the action. The legal question of borrowing is less interesting than the mythographic one: both works stage a lowly urban male conscripted into a cosmic drama, a luminous figure of salvation, and a darkness that threatens the whole. They diverge at the decisive point. *L'Incal* resolves its drama through gnosis and cosmic recapitulation; *The Fifth Element* resolves it through love between two persons. The divergence is the subject of this dissertation.

Pierre Christin and Jean-Claude Mézières's *Valérian et Laureline*, serialised in *Pilote* from 1967, supplied the film's textures of interstellar bureaucracy, alien commerce, and comic deflation. Mézières worked on the film's designs from the early 1990s, and his album *Les Cercles du pouvoir* (1994), with its taxi driver navigating a stratified city, belongs to a traffic of motifs between album and film that ran in both directions. Enki Bilal's *La Foire aux immortels* (1980), the first volume of the Nikopol trilogy, adds the most specific mythological correspondence: a pyramid-shaped craft of Egyptian gods—Horus, Anubis, Bastet—hovering over a fascist Paris of 2023, and a god seeking a human body through which to act. Bilal's Jill Bioskop, blue-haired and blue-lipped, belongs with the film's blue Diva to an iconography of the azure woman examined below.

Yves Klein: The Void, the Leap, the Blue III.6

No French artist of the twentieth century is closer to the film's elemental imagination than Yves Klein. Klein patented International Klein Blue in 1960 and treated it as the colour of the immaterial, the infinite, and the void. In the same year he staged *Le Saut dans le vide*, the photomontage in which he appears to leap from a wall into empty air above a suburban street; and he produced the *Anthropometries*, in which nude women pressed their blue-painted bodies onto canvas as "living brushes." In 1960–1961 he made *Cosmogonies*, canvases exposed to rain and wind, and fire paintings executed with a flame-thrower; his studies of Max Heindel's Rosicrucian cosmology informed a lifelong programme to make the elements themselves paint. Klein's oeuvre is a fifth-element project avant la lettre: fire, water, air, and the body, gathered under the sign of a blue that stands for the void.

The film's homologies are threefold. Leeloo's leap from the ledge into the depths of the city is Klein's leap into the void, performed by a body that cannot be harmed by it. The Diva Plavalaguna—whose name reads in Croatian as *plava laguna*, "blue lagoon"—is an azure body that carries the elements inside her. And Besson's own *Le Grand Bleu* (1988) had already made blue the colour of a transcendence that competes with human love. Wassily Kandinsky's *Über das Geistige in der Kunst* (1911) called blue the typically heavenly colour, whose deepening summons the beholder toward

the infinite; the film's chromatic theology, examined further in Chapter VII, places its divine singer in that colour and its divine heroine under hair the colour of fire.

III.7 The *Cinéma du look* and the Neo-Baroque

Raphaël Bassan's 1989 essay in *La Revue du cinéma* grouped Beineix, Besson, and Carax as "neo-baroque" directors of the image, and the label *cinéma du look* has since served both celebration and dismissal. Two intertexts with Beineix are decisive. The movement's founding film, Beineix's *Diva* (1981), turns on an opera soprano who refuses to be recorded and on the illicit tape that captures her voice. Besson's Diva, a soprano who sings once and dies, completes the figure: the voice that cannot be possessed is the vessel of what is most precious. And Zorg is the name of the narrator-protagonist of Philippe Djian's *37°2 le matin* (1985), filmed by Beineix in 1986 as *Betty Blue*. Whether homage or coincidence, the film's villain bears the name of the *look*'s most famous lover.

Omar Calabrese's *L'età neobarocca* (1987) defined the neo-baroque by its taste for rhythm and repetition, limit and excess, detail and fragment, instability and metamorphosis, disorder and chaos, the knot and the labyrinth. The definition reads like a production brief for *The Fifth Element*. Gilles Deleuze's *Le Pli* (1988), published the same year as *Le Grand Bleu*, figured the Baroque as a house of two floors: a lower floor of matter, pierced by windows, and an upper floor of the soul, closed and draped with folds. The film's vertical New York, its polluted ground and its airborne strata, its windowless apartment-cells folding beds out of walls, is a Baroque house in Deleuze's sense, and its plot is a traffic between floors. Serge Daney's late distinction between *l'image*, which presupposes an other, and *le visuel*, the self-sufficient optical product of advertising and television, sharpened the case against the *look*. *The Fifth Element* answers Daney by reversal: it is built entirely from *le visuel*, and it concludes by insisting that the only thing that saves is addressed to an other.

III.8 The Euro-Blockbuster and the *Exception culturelle*

The film was made in the aftermath of the 1993 GATT negotiations in which France secured the exclusion of audiovisual products from free-trade

liberalisation under the banner of the *exception culturelle*. A decade earlier, at the UNESCO conference in Mexico City in 1982, Culture Minister Jack Lang had denounced American cultural and financial imperialism, and the television serial *Dallas* became, in French debate, an emblem of the American audiovisual export. *The Fifth Element* is a French answer to Hollywood in Hollywood's language: an English-language spectacle with an American star, financed and controlled from Paris.

Its hero's name encodes the hybrid. Korben is Gallic in sound—it echoes the Old French *corbin*, "raven"—and Dallas is the most notorious American cultural export of the 1980s. The President of the Federated Territories bears, less one letter, the name of Charles Lindbergh, whose solo flight of 1927 joined New York to Paris—and who, as the leading voice of the America First Committee, named "the British, the Jewish, and the Roosevelt administration" as the forces pushing the United States toward war in a speech at Des Moines on 11 September 1941, three years after accepting the Service Cross of the German Eagle from Hermann Göring. Whether the name is an allusion at all is uncertain; if it is, it carries isolationism and antisemitism along with transatlantic flight. The division of theological labour is equally transatlantic. The Supreme Being—devised by a French director, speaking a Divine Language he invented, and named in the vocabulary of the Revolution—is completed by the plain declarative sincerity of an American action hero whose persona had been forged in *Die Hard* (1988). Europe supplies the cosmology; America supplies the sentence that activates it. The film's political allegory is not anti-American. It is an allegory of complementarity in which neither the metaphysics nor the sincerity suffices alone.

The Bessonian Problematic III.9

Within Besson's oeuvre, *The Fifth Element* occupies a pivot. *Le Dernier Combat* (1983), a nearly wordless post-apocalypse, imagines a humanity that has lost speech; Leeloo arrives speaking a language no one understands. *Le Grand Bleu* (1988) ends with its free-diver choosing the abyss over the woman who loves him and carries his child; *The Fifth Element* stages the same alternative—transcendence or love—and reverses the choice. *Nikita* (1990) and *Léon* (1994) establish the Bessonian heroine as a lethal innocent,

a girl made into a weapon, whom the plot must restore to a capacity for love —though the second of these films frames the bond between a hitman and a twelve-year-old girl with romantic undertones that critics have long found troubling (Chapter VII.9); Leeloo is that figure raised to cosmic power. After the film, *The Messenger* (1999) casts Jovovich again as a divinely commissioned saviour, Joan of Arc, undone by doubt rather than completed by love; *Angel-A* (2005) gives an angel the task of teaching a man to love himself; and *Lucy* (2014) imagines a woman who absorbs all knowledge and dissolves into omnipresent information without ever loving anyone. *Lucy* is the anti-*Fifth Element*: the same apotheosis through knowledge, without the interval that redeems it. *Valerian and the City of a Thousand Planets* (2017) closes the circle by adapting Mézières directly.

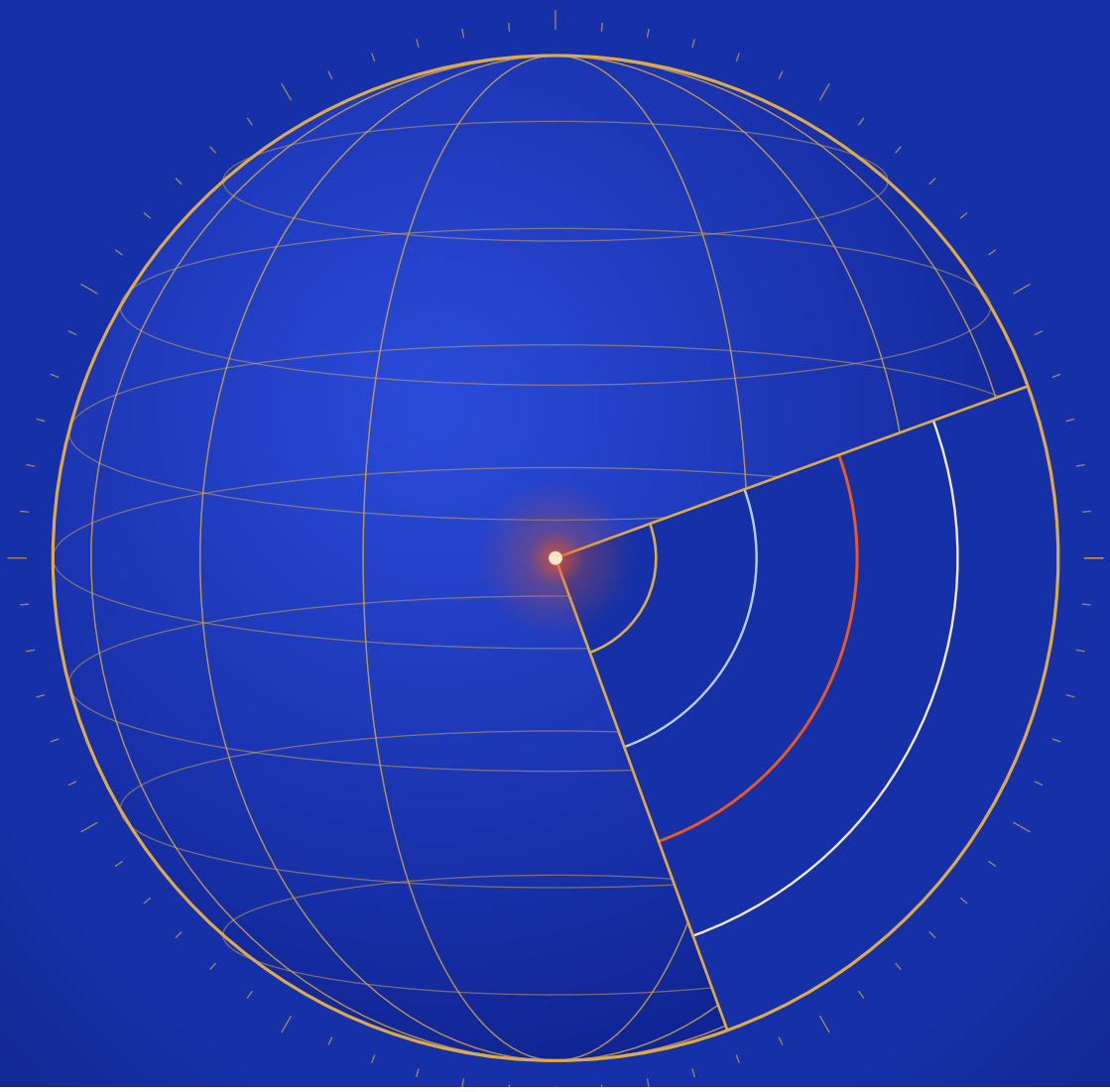
The Bessonian problematic can be stated as a single question that recurs across forty years: does transcendence lie in the absolute—the abyss, the archive, total information—or in the finite relation between two persons? *The Fifth Element* is the film in which Besson answered most decisively for the relation.

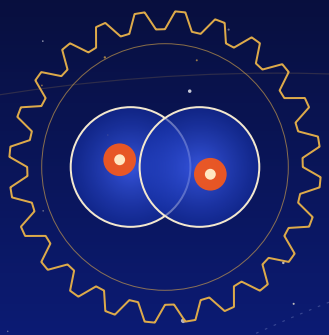
III.10 Kamen and the Initiatory Economy of Genre

Robert Mark Kamen's contribution is harder to isolate but structurally legible. *The Karate Kid* (1984), which drew on his own experience of martial training, is an initiation narrative in which menial gestures—waxing a car, sanding a floor, painting a fence—turn out to have been martial forms all along, and in which the master's doctrine is balance. Its mentor bears the name of Chōjun Miyagi, founder of the Gōjū-ryū ("hard-soft") style. *The Fifth Element*'s climax obeys the same law: the most ordinary bodily acts—breathing, sweating, scooping sand, striking a match—turn out to be liturgy, and the hard instruments of force fail where the soft act of love succeeds. Kamen's *Lethal Weapon 3* (1992) supplies the mismatched male double act transposed onto Korben and Ruby Rhod. Whatever the precise allocation of authorship, the screenplay's architecture fuses Besson's maximal mythopoeia with an American economy of initiation, comic pairing, and countdown. The fusion is not a compromise. It is the formal condition under which a cosmology of the interval can be carried by a popular genre.

Part Two

Anatomies





Chapter IV

The Hand and the Machine

Regeneration, Biopower, and the Manufacture of Gods

The Supreme Being enters the twenty-third century as debris: a gloved hand, recovered from the wreck of the Mondoshawan vessel, from whose surviving cells a military laboratory regenerates an entire body. The sequence—skeleton, musculature, skin, bandage—is among the most celebrated in the film and the most theologically compressed. It condenses an anthropology of the hand, a theology of the laboratory, a modern mythology of the artificial woman, a scriptural conception of the genome, a linguistics of divine speech, and a politics of the body. This chapter takes each in turn and argues that the laboratory, which believes it is manufacturing a weapon, is in fact performing a birth.

IV.1 The Hand: Instrument of Instruments

Aristotle called the hand "the instrument of instruments" (*De Anima* III.8, 432a1), and in *Parts of Animals* (IV.10, 687a) he corrected Anaxagoras, who had said that human beings are the wisest of animals because they have hands: rather, Aristotle replied, they have hands because they are the wisest. The hand is the organ through which intelligence becomes efficacious in the world; it is the bodily figure of mediation between mind and matter. Heidegger, lecturing in 1951–1952 on what is called thinking, went

further: thinking itself, he said, is a handicraft (*Hand-Werk*), and the hand is not a grasping organ like the paw but the site where the human being's relation to being is enacted.

That the Supreme Being survives *as a hand* is therefore not an incidental plot device. What remains of the divine after catastrophe is its organ of mediation. And the scene that regenerates the whole from this part inverts the most famous image of creation in Western art. In Michelangelo's *Creation of Adam*, the hand of God extends toward the hand of man and confers life across an interval. In Besson's laboratory, human hands at a console recover the hand of God and confer on it a body. The interval between the two fingers on the Sistine ceiling—the most famous gap in the history of painting—is the gap the film will spend its remaining two hours closing, and it will close it not with technology but with a kiss.

The motto of Fritz Lang's *Metropolis* (1927), the founding film of the vertical megacity, adds a third term. The mediator between the head and the hands, its intertitles insist, must be the heart. *The Fifth Element* distributes the triad with diagrammatic clarity: the head is the archive Leeloo will ingest, the hands are the laboratory and the stones, and the heart is the missing term without which neither head nor hands can act.

Osiris, the Opening of the Mouth, and the Bandaged Body IV.2

The regeneration from a fragment has an Egyptian prototype. In the version transmitted by Plutarch (*De Iside et Osiride* 18), Seth dismembers Osiris and scatters the pieces; Isis gathers them, fashions a replacement for the one part she cannot find, and restores her husband to a life that is also the template of Egyptian resurrection. The dead body is reassembled, wrapped, and then animated by the *Opening of the Mouth* (*wpt-r*), the ritual by which priests touched the mouth of a mummy or a statue with instruments to restore breath, speech, and the capacity to eat. The film's laboratory follows the Osirian sequence: fragment, reassembly, wrapping, awakening. Leeloo emerges in strips of white—the "thermal bandages" Gaultier designed—which inevitably recall the mummy's wrappings and, through them, the most famous bandaged woman in cinema, the creature of James Whale's *Bride of Frankenstein* (1935).

The citation of Whale carries a plot. The Bride, assembled by men to be a mate for the creature, rejects him on sight; her refusal is the first act of the only character in that film who was made to belong to someone. Leeloo's first act of will toward Korben repeats the refusal, and the act she refuses should be named plainly. Korben kisses her while she is unconscious, without her consent: a non-consensual sexual act, which many legal systems would class as sexual assault, committed by the film's hero against a woman who cannot respond. She wakes and holds a gun to his head; the phrase she speaks in her own language, translated later by Cornelius, is that this must never happen without her permission. The first sentence of the Divine Language that humans understand is therefore a law of consent, issued in answer to a violation. The film plays the episode partly for comedy, and its narrative never stages a reckoning with it. Its moral arc runs from that assault to the final, salvific kiss, which Leeloo returns; but the film shows reciprocation, not an explicit grant of the permission she demanded, and it lets its hero's redemption on this point be asserted rather than earned. Chapters VII and IX return to what this does to the theodicy.

IV.3 *Une Machine à faire des dieux*

Bergson's final sentence in *Les Deux Sources* named the universe a machine for the making of gods. The phrase was metaphysical: the universe produces, through evolution and mysticism, beings capable of divine love. *The Fifth Element* literalises it. A machine—a cylinder of light and scanning beams, operated by technicians under military supervision—makes a god. Bergson's metaphor becomes apparatus.

Le Corbusier had defined the house as *une machine à habiter*, a machine for living in (*Vers une architecture*, 1923). The film sets the two machines side by side. Korben's cramped apartment, a single compartment fitted with fold-away fixtures, is Le Corbusier's machine reduced to a cell; the laboratory is Bergson's. Late modernity, on this showing, can build machines for living in and machines for making gods. It cannot build the relation that makes either worth having.

The literalisation is double-edged, and its edges are Heideggerian. In "Die Frage nach der Technik" (1954), Heidegger argued that modern technology is a mode of revealing he called *Gestell*, enframing, which discloses

everything—rivers, forests, human beings—as standing-reserve (*Bestand*), resources on call for further ordering. The laboratory of the Federated Territories enframes the divine: it treats the remnant of the Supreme Being as a resource, regenerates it as an asset, and surrounds it with a transparent containment cell and a general who wants to know whether the asset can be controlled. Yet Heidegger closed the same lecture with Hölderlin's lines from "Patmos" (1803): where danger is, there grows the saving power also. And in the *Spiegel* interview recorded in 1966 and published in 1976, he declared: *Nur noch ein Gott kann uns retten*—only a god can still save us.

The film stages both of Heidegger's sentences at once and with an irony he would not have relished. Only a god can save us; and the god is produced by *Gestell* itself, inside the very apparatus Heidegger identified as the extreme danger. The saving power grows where the danger is. But the god so produced does not remain standing-reserve for a single scene. Leeloo breaches her enclosure within minutes of waking, shattering the glass that contains her, and flees. The first act of the manufactured god is to refuse manufacture. Technology can make a god; it cannot keep one.

The sentence has a history that the film's irony should not obscure. Heidegger joined the National Socialist party in May 1933 and served as rector of the University of Freiburg in 1933–1934. The *Spiegel* interview was recorded in 1966 largely to address that record, on condition that it appear only after his death; and the private notebooks published from 2014 contain antisemitic passages written while the regime he had served was persecuting, and then murdering, Europe's Jews. "Only a god can save us" was thus spoken by a philosopher who never publicly confronted his own part in the catastrophe. The film's answer differs on exactly that point: in its cosmos the god cannot save without a human act, and the act is one of responsibility to another person.

The Perfect Woman: From *L'Ève future* to 1997 IV.4

The laboratory's certification of Leeloo as "perfect" places her in a specifically modern lineage that runs through French literature before it reaches the cinema. In Villiers de l'Isle-Adam's *L'Ève future* (1886), a fictionalised Thomas Edison constructs for his friend Lord Ewald an *andréide*—the novel coined the word—named Hadaly: a mechanical woman who repro-

duces the beauty of Ewald's mistress while correcting what he deplores in her mind. Hadaly is perfect in form and, through an occult intervention, receives something like a soul; she perishes in a shipwreck on the voyage to her new life. Villiers's novel is the template for the modern fantasy of the woman made perfect by male science, and for the anxiety that such perfection is uninhabitable.

The lineage passes through Ovid's Pygmalion (*Metamorphoses* X), Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein; or, The Modern Prometheus* (1818), the false Maria of *Metropolis*—a machine-woman built to sow chaos among the workers—and Whale's Bride. In 1997 it reached a peculiar density. In the same year as *The Fifth Element*, Jean-Pierre Jeunet, another French director working in Hollywood, released *Alien Resurrection*, in which Ellen Ripley is cloned from preserved blood samples by a military-scientific establishment that wants to harvest what she carries; and Andrew Niccol's *Gattaca* imagined a society stratified by genetic perfection and celebrated the imperfect man who outperforms it. Three films of a single year asked what it means to make a perfect body, and whom such a body belongs to.

Laura Mulvey's (1975) account of classical cinema's organisation of the woman as spectacle—her "to-be-looked-at-ness" for a male spectator relayed through a male protagonist—applies to the regeneration sequence with almost textbook exactness: the nude female body assembled, layer by layer, under the gaze of male scientists, a male general, and a camera. But the film sets the gaze against its object's indifference to it. Leeloo is unashamed of her nakedness, as Adam and Eve were before the Fall (Genesis 2:25), and the embarrassment in subsequent scenes belongs entirely to the men who look at her. The gaze is made visible as the gaze of the fallen. Whether this critique redeems the spectacle it critiques is a question Chapter VII takes up; here it suffices to note that the film's "perfect woman" differs from Hadaly in one crucial respect. Hadaly is perfect *for* someone. Leeloo is perfect for no one, and her first word to the man who will love her is a refusal.

IV.5 The Genome as Scripture, and the Cell of 1997

The scientist who supervises the regeneration explains the miracle in the idiom of molecular biology: ordinary human DNA, he observes, carries

a modest number of genetic "memory" groups; this specimen carries an immense number, packed beyond anything human. The genome is figured as an archive, a book of life, and the Supreme Being as an informational surplus. The figure was current. The Human Genome Project, launched in 1990, had made the genome the master-text of late-twentieth-century biology, and its public rhetoric readily borrowed theological diction: reading the genome was described as reading the language of life itself. The Johannine Word made flesh (John 1:14) becomes the code made flesh.

The historical coincidence is striking enough to record in detail. On 22 February 1997, the Roslin Institute announced the birth of Dolly, a sheep cloned by somatic-cell nuclear transfer from a cell of an adult ewe's mammary gland; the paper by Ian Wilmut and colleagues appeared in *Nature* on 27 February. It was the first mammal produced from an adult somatic cell. Ten weeks later *The Fifth Element* opened at Cannes with a sequence in which a complete adult body is regenerated from a single surviving cell. The film had been in development for years and could not have been influenced by Dolly; but it was received in a world that had just learned that the fantasy of regeneration from a fragment had crossed into fact.

The scientist's vocabulary of genetic perfection has a history that the film's comedy does not acknowledge. Francis Galton coined the word "eugenics" in 1883. In the United States, state sterilisation laws, upheld by the Supreme Court in *Buck v. Bell* (1927), led to the sterilisation of more than 60,000 people, most of them poor, disabled, or institutionalised. Nazi Germany's sterilisation law of 1933 led to some 400,000 sterilisations, and from 1939 its "euthanasia" programme murdered disabled patients: about 70,000 in the centralised gassings of Aktion T4 in 1940–1941 and, by most estimates, more than 200,000 in all (Friedlander 1995). The certification of a being as perfect by the measure of her genome speaks that vocabulary. The film's own answer, that a perfect genome is impotent without relation, is also an answer to it, and *Gattaca*, released the same year, made the answer explicit.

The film's critique of the informational conception of life is deferred to the archive scene examined in Chapter VI, but its premise is laid here. The genome that the scientist calls perfect contains everything except the one thing the plot will require. Perfection, measured as information, is not yet the capacity to act. The genome is a scripture without an interpreter.

IV.6 The Divine Language: Adamic Speech, the Golem, and the Second Fall

Leeloo awakens speaking a language that no one but Cornelius can follow —a constructed "Divine Language" that Besson devised and that Jovovich learned to speak fluently. Walter Benjamin's early essay "Über Sprache überhaupt und über die Sprache des Menschen" (1916) supplies the theoretical frame. For Benjamin, the language of Adam was a naming language in which words communicated the spiritual essence of things; the Fall was a fall into the "prattle" of human languages, which judge and signify rather than name, and Babel completed the dispersion. Umberto Eco's *La ricerca della lingua perfetta nella cultura europea* (1993) traced the European dream of recovering that language—Adamic, universal, philosophical—from the Kabbalists through John Wilkins and Leibniz. The film's "perfect being" arrives speaking the perfect language and must learn an imperfect one in order to act among human beings. Her descent into English, through the alphabetical ingestion of an encyclopedia, is a second fall, and it is the fall that brings her knowledge of war.

The Jewish tradition of the golem adds a further register. In the Prague legend associated with Rabbi Judah Loew, a figure of clay is animated by the divine name, or by the word *emet* ("truth") inscribed on its forehead; erasing the first letter leaves *met* ("dead"), and the figure returns to dust. The *Sefer Yetzirah* had taught that the world itself was created through the combinations of the Hebrew letters. Life, in this tradition, is a function of the right word. *The Fifth Element* belongs to the golem lineage with one decisive difference. Its manufactured being is animated by technology, not by a name; but she is *activated*—made capable of her divine function—by a sentence. The film relocates the animating word from the forehead of the made being to the mouth of the human being who loves her.

IV.7 Biopower, Bare Life, and the Multipass

Michel Foucault's account of biopower, in the final chapter of *La Volonté de savoir* (1976) and in the lecture course of the same year, describes the modern displacement of the sovereign's right to take life or let live by a power to make live and let die: a power that invests bodies and populations, measures, optimises, and administers life itself. The laboratory in which

Leeloo is regenerated is a theatre of biopower in its purest form—life produced on the state's initiative, under military supervision, as an instrument of security.

Giorgio Agamben's *Homo Sacer* (1995) sharpened Foucault's thesis through the Greek distinction between *zōē*, the bare fact of being alive, and *bios*, a qualified, political form of life, and located the founding act of sovereignty in the production of bare life—life included in the political order only through its exposure to power. Leeloo awakens as pure *zōē*: naked, speechless in any language the polis recognises, without name, papers, or status. Her flight from the laboratory is a flight from bare life; and her entry into the polis is marked by a document.

The Multipass—the universal identity card of the Federated Territories—is the film's most quoted prop, and Leeloo's delighted, repeated presentation of it at the spaceport is among its most famous gags. The gag conceals an Arendtian point. In *The Origins of Totalitarianism* (1951), Hannah Arendt argued that the stateless refugee revealed the emptiness of abstract human rights: the only right that mattered was "the right to have rights," membership in a political community that could guarantee the others. The Supreme Being arrives stateless, and her joy at possessing papers is the joy of a being who has acquired the right to have rights. That she acquires them under Korben's surname, travelling as his wife, makes the point more exact still: her political existence is constituted by a relation. She enters the polis not as an individual bearer of rights but as one term of a pair.

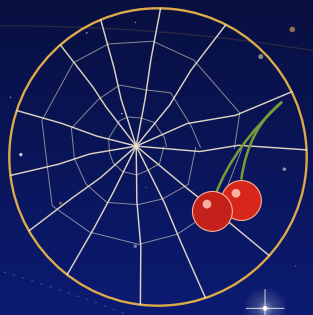
The Multipass has a Gnostic shadow. In the cosmologies reported by Origen in *Contra Celsum* (VI.31), the soul ascending through the planetary spheres must recite passwords to the archons who guard each gate. The vertical city of *The Fifth Element*, with its checkpoints, its police scanners, and its spaceport controls, is an archonic cosmos; the Multipass is the password. The descended god must carry papers to pass the powers of the world she has come to save.

Natality: The Miracle That Saves the World IV.8

Arendt's *The Human Condition* (1958) gives the regeneration its final sense. Against a philosophical tradition that had defined the human by mortality, Arendt defined it by natality: the fact that human beings are

born, and that each birth introduces into the world a newcomer capable of beginning something new. She cited Augustine (*De civitate Dei* XII.21): *initium ut esset homo creatus est*—that there might be a beginning, man was created. And she wrote that the miracle that saves the world, the realm of human affairs, from its normal, natural ruin is ultimately the fact of natality, which is actualised in action—and, for Arendt, action is disclosed above all in speech.

The laboratory believes it is manufacturing a weapon. It is in fact attending a birth. The film's world is ruled by Zorg's doctrine of destruction and the state's doctrine of force; its salvation begins with a newcomer whose first acts are refusal and flight, and it is completed by a speech-act. The film thus reproduces Arendt's sequence exactly: natality, then action, then the word that discloses who acts. The Supreme Being is born; she must still be spoken to.



Chapter V

Zorg, or the Theodicy of Breakage

Creative Destruction, Mephistophelean Economy, and the Mimetic Shadow

Jean-Baptiste Emanuel Zorg is the only character in *The Fifth Element* who articulates a philosophy, and he does so in a set-piece that functions as the film's explicit counter-thesis. Receiving Father Cornelius in his office, Zorg sweeps a glass from his desk; small cleaning robots emerge to clear the shards; and Zorg explains, with the serenity of a man expounding a law of nature, that his gesture has given life—work for the robots, for the engineers who design them, for the manufacturers who build them, for an entire chain of employment—and that life itself issues from destruction, disorder, and chaos. Moments later, Zorg chokes on a cherry. His robots do nothing. Cornelius, whom he has just threatened, strikes him on the back and saves his life.

This chapter reads the sequence as a compressed treatise in theodicy and political economy. Zorg's sermon condenses two centuries of the doctrine that destruction is generative; the cherry refutes it by a gesture; and the master Zorg serves—an Evil that grows when it is attacked—reveals what the doctrine finally is.

V.1 The Broken Window: Bastiat's "Unseen"

In 1850 the French economist Frédéric Bastiat published *Ce qu'on voit et ce qu'on ne voit pas*, whose first chapter, "La Vitre cassée," is the most famous parable in economic literature. A shopkeeper's careless son breaks a pane of glass. The onlookers console the father: misfortunes have their uses; if no glass were ever broken, what would become of the glaziers? Bastiat answers that the onlookers have counted only *what is seen*—the six francs paid to the glazier, the work created—and have ignored *what is not seen*: the shoes or the book the shopkeeper would have bought with those six francs had the window survived. Society, Bastiat concludes, has simply lost a pane of glass.

Zorg's sermon is the broken-window fallacy delivered as metaphysics. Its structure is identical to the onlookers' reasoning—destruction is justified by the visible activity it generates—and its scale is cosmic: Zorg will extend the argument from a glass to a planet, selling to a cosmic adversary the means of destroying all life, and presumably expecting to profit from what follows. That the refutation of Zorg's doctrine was formulated by a French liberal economist a century and a half before the film is part of the French genealogy reconstructed in Chapter III. But the film supplies a refutation Bastiat did not imagine. The "unseen" of Zorg's economy is not merely the foregone pair of shoes. It is the entire order of unremunerated care—the gesture that saves a choking man for nothing—which no economy of destruction can see, because it produces no transaction.

The historical referent is not hard to find. Zorg is an armaments industrialist, and the doctrine that war and its preparation sustain employment and growth was, in the twentieth century, not a parable but a policy. Dwight Eisenhower's farewell address of 17 January 1961 warned against the "military-industrial complex," the permanent armaments industry whose interests might come to shape the decisions of the state that bought its products. Zorg Industries is the military-industrial complex as a single personality, and its owner's theology is the self-justification of an economy that profits from what it destroys.

V.2 A Genealogy of Creative Destruction

Zorg's doctrine has a long pedigree, and the film's villain stands at its point of convergence.

Its archaic root is Heraclitus. War, says fragment B53, is the father of all and the king of all; it shows some as gods and others as men, makes some slaves and others free. Fragment B80 adds that war is common, that justice is strife, and that all things come to pass through strife and necessity (Kahn 1979). In Heraclitus the doctrine is cosmological and impersonal, a statement about the tension of opposites that constitutes the world. Its modern romantic form is Mikhail Bakunin's, in the essay "Die Reaktion in Deutschland" published under a pseudonym in 1842, which ends with the sentence that became the motto of revolutionary anarchism: *Die Lust der Zerstörung ist eine schaffende Lust*—the passion for destruction is a creative passion. Nietzsche's Zarathustra, in the discourse on self-overcoming, declares that whoever must be a creator in good and evil must first be an annihilator and break values.

Its economic form passes through Marx and Engels. In the *Manifesto of the Communist Party* (1848) the bourgeoisie appears as the most revolutionary class in history, constantly overturning the instruments of production, so that, in Samuel Moore's 1888 translation, "all that is solid melts into air, all that is holy is profaned." The sentence is elemental—earth dissolved into air—and Marshall Berman (1982) made it the emblem of modernity itself. Werner Sombart's *Krieg und Kapitalismus* (1913) argued that war had been a creative force in the formation of capitalism, and anticipated the phrase that Joseph Schumpeter made canonical in *Capitalism, Socialism and Democracy* (1942), chapter 7: "This process of Creative Destruction is the essential fact about capitalism."

Its aesthetic form is Futurist. F. T. Marinetti's founding manifesto, published on the front page of *Le Figaro* on 20 February 1909, proposed to glorify war as the world's only hygiene. Antonio Sant'Elia exhibited the drawings of his *Città Nuova*—the first vertical megacity of the modernist imagination, with its stacked levels of traffic and its elevator towers—in Milan in 1914, the year of the film's prologue, and died in the war in 1916. The vertical New York of *The Fifth Element* descends, through *Metropolis* and *Blade Runner*, from the city drawn by an architect whose movement glorified the war that killed him.

Marinetti's glorification of war was not only aesthetic. His Futurist Political Party merged into Mussolini's movement in 1919; he signed the Manifesto of the Fascist Intellectuals in 1925; and he hailed Fascist Italy's

invasion of Ethiopia in 1935, a war in which Italian forces used mustard gas against Ethiopian soldiers and civilians. Walter Benjamin's epilogue to the essay on the work of art, examined in Chapter VII, quotes Marinetti's manifesto on that war as the exemplary case of a politics that renders destruction beautiful. The doctrine of generative destruction that the film gives its villain and the aestheticised violence it stages in the Diva's recital therefore meet in a single documented figure, and Benjamin's answer to Marinetti is the film's own.

Zorg gathers these strands, but with a decisive inflection. In a later scene he expresses contempt for warriors: their honour, he remarks, has killed millions and saved no one. This is not the voice of Marinetti, for whom war was heroic, nor of Heraclitus, for whom it was cosmic. It is the voice of what Schumpeter, in his 1919 essay on the sociology of imperialisms, described as the rational, calculating, essentially unheroic bourgeois for whom the warrior ethos is an atavism. Max Weber's typology in *Wirtschaft und Gesellschaft* (1922) clarifies the opposition. The Mangalores act value-rationally (*wertrational*): their honour code requires them to die rather than surrender, regardless of consequences. Zorg acts instrumentally (*zweckrational*): he calculates. He is the creative destroyer after the death of heroism—destruction without glory, war as a line of business.

V.3 Mephistopheles, Pangloss, and the Satan of Artillery

Goethe's Mephistopheles introduces himself to Faust as "part of that power which eternally wills evil and eternally works good" (*Ein Teil von jener Kraft, / Die stets das Böse will und stets das Gute schafft*; *Faust I*, 1335–1336), and then as "the spirit that always negates," adding the justification that everything that comes into being deserves to perish (1338–1340). Zorg is a Mephistopheles turned inside out. Mephistopheles wills evil and, despite himself, produces good. Zorg claims to will the good—employment, life, growth—and produces evil. His sermon is a Mephistophelean self-description recast as a corporate mission statement.

It is also a theodicy. Leibniz's *Essais de Théodicée* (1710) argued that the evils of the world are permitted by a good God as necessary components of the best of all possible worlds. Voltaire's *Candide* (1759) answered with Pangloss, who explains every catastrophe—syphilis, war, the Lisbon earth-

quake—as a necessary link in the chain of the best, and whose optimism survives every refutation the novel inflicts on him. Zorg is Pangloss as an industrialist. Every broken thing, in his account, is justified by what it sets in motion; and like Pangloss he is immune to evidence, because his theory explains any outcome in advance. Voltaire's novel ends by abandoning theodicy for practice: *il faut cultiver notre jardin*—we must cultivate our garden. Cornelius's blow between the shoulder-blades is the garden cultivated: a small, local, practical act that does not explain evil but prevents a death.

Milton supplies the theological ancestry of Zorg's profession. In Book VI of *Paradise Lost*, during the war in heaven, Satan invents artillery, digging the materials of gunpowder from the soil of heaven and casting cannon to break the loyal angels' ranks. The first armaments manufacturer of English epic is the devil. And in Book I Mammon, "the least erected Spirit that fell," whose gaze was always bent downward to the gold of heaven's pavement, directs the building of Pandaemonium. Zorg, with his towering corporate headquarters and his catalogue of weapons, is Mammon and the Satanic artillerist in one, and his axiology is Satan's: "Evil be thou my Good" (IV.110).

Maistre's Altar and Bastiat's Shoes: Two French Answers V.4

If Bastiat is the liberal refutation of the creative destroyer, Joseph de Maistre is his reactionary apotheosis. In the seventh dialogue of *Les Soirées de Saint-Pétersbourg* (1821), Maistre declares war divine in itself, and describes the whole earth, continually steeped in blood, as an immense altar on which everything that lives must be immolated without end, without measure, without respite, until the consummation of things. In the first dialogue he had made the executioner the cornerstone of social order. Maistre's providential violence is the theological form of Zorg's economic one: both naturalise destruction by making it the hidden engine of order.

The two French answers, Bastiat's and Maistre's, define the alternatives the film rejects and accepts. Against Maistre, the film denies that destruction is sacred: its cosmic adversary is precisely the principle of unending immolation, and its salvation consists in refusing the altar. With Bastiat, it insists that destruction is loss. But it adds what neither economist nor

theologian supplied: that the decisive reality is not a ledger of losses and gains but a gesture of care, which belongs to no ledger at all.

V.5 The Cherry: *Sorge*, *Fürsorge*, and the Robots That Cannot Care

The villain's name invites a hermeneutic that need not be intended to be illuminating. In Dutch, *zorg* means care, concern, worry; its German cognate *Sorge* is the term by which Heidegger, in *Sein und Zeit* (1927, §41), designates the very being of human existence. Heidegger distinguished two modes of care. *Besorgen*, concern, is the circumspective handling of equipment—the ready-to-hand world of tools, materials, and tasks. *Fürsorge*, solicitude, is care for other persons; and it has two forms (§26): a solicitude that "leaps in" for the other (*einspringende Fürsorge*), taking over what the other cannot do, and a solicitude that "leaps ahead" (*vorausspringende Fürsorge*), freeing the other for their own possibilities.

Zorg is *Besorgen* incarnate and *Fürsorge* annihilated. His world is a world of equipment: weapons demonstrated, stones treated as assets, robots dispatched, subordinates disposed of. His robots are *Besorgen* automated —machines of reparation produced by and for an economy of breakage, perfectly competent to sweep up a glass and perfectly incapable of saving their master from a cherry stone. Cornelius's intervention is *einspringende Fürsorge* in its most literal possible form: he leaps in and does for the choking man what the man cannot do for himself. The scene thus stages the distinction on which the whole film turns. An economy organised around destruction can produce machines that repair things. It cannot produce care for persons, because care has no product.

Emmanuel Levinas would locate the scene's ethical force elsewhere: in the face of the other in distress, which commands before any calculation, so that Cornelius answers the vulnerability of a man who has just threatened him without asking whether he deserves it (*Totalité et infini*, 1961). And the Jewish mystical tradition offers a further reading of the broken glass, developed in Chapter IX. In the Lurianic Kabbalah of sixteenth-century Safed, creation itself began with a breakage, the shattering of the vessels (*shevirat ha-kelim*) that could not contain the divine light; the human task is *tikkun*, repair. Zorg accepts the shattering as first principle and automates

the repair, emptying it of ethical content. The film restores to repair its meaning as an act between persons.

The broken glass recurs. Zorg breaks a glass to demonstrate that destruction is profitable. Leeloo, minutes after her regeneration, breaks the glass of her containment cell to escape the state that would own her. The film thus distinguishes two shatterings: destruction as commodity and destruction as liberation—the breaking of a vessel that holds life captive. The difference between them is the difference between Zorg's theodicy and the film's.

A third shattering completes the figure. At the close of a Jewish wedding a glass is broken, by custom in memory of the destruction of the Temple in Jerusalem, burned by the Roman army under Titus in 70 CE. The breakage is neither undone by the union nor allowed to spoil it; destruction is remembered inside love. That is also the structure of the film's ending: the Evil is not annihilated but kept in the sky as a dead moon (Chapter IX.6), and the lovers' union takes place under its sign. Zorg's glass forgets; Leeloo's glass escapes; the wedding glass remembers.

The Weapon That Kills Its Owner V.6

Zorg's showpiece product, the ZF-1, is demonstrated in a parody of a sales presentation: a catalogue of lethal functions, each more extravagant than the last, crowned by a concealed self-destruct mechanism. The commodity of destruction contains its owner's annihilation as a feature. And Zorg's own end obeys the same law. Having gone to *Fhloston Paradise* for stones he believes he has secured, and having found his case empty, he returns to the liner and halts the countdown on his own bomb with seconds to spare —only to die in a second detonation he did not set and cannot stop. The engineer is, in Hamlet's phrase, hoist with his own petard (III.iv).

The structure is dialectical in the strict sense. An economy of destruction does not stand outside the destruction it sells; it is consumed by its own logic, as Marx argued that capital produces its own gravediggers and as Hegel's cunning of reason (*List der Vernunft*) uses particular passions to accomplish ends they did not intend. Zorg's death is not a punishment imposed from outside the system. It is the system's truth arriving at its administrator.

V.7 Mr. Shadow: Jung, the Mark on the Forehead, and Girard's Satan

Zorg calls his master Mr. Shadow, and the name invites Jung. In analytical psychology the Shadow is the repressed and disowned portion of the personality, which, unacknowledged, is projected onto others and acts through possession. The collective shadow of a civilisation is its accumulated capacity for organised violence. When the Evil speaks to Zorg, a wound on his forehead bleeds. The image is apocalyptic before it is psychological. Revelation 13:16–17 describes the second Beast causing all to receive a mark in their right hand or in their foreheads, "that no man might buy or sell, save he that had the mark." The mark of the Beast is economic. Zorg, the merchant who bleeds from the forehead when the Shadow speaks, is the Beast's trader—the figure through whom cosmic evil enters the market.

The Evil's defining property, however, is established before Zorg appears. When a warship fires on it, it absorbs the assault and grows. Violence is its nourishment. René Girard's mimetic theory gives this property its fullest sense. In *La Violence et le sacré* (1972) and *Des choses cachées depuis la fondation du monde* (1978) Girard argued that violence is mimetic and contagious: each blow imitates and escalates the last, so that rivalries spread until a community discharges them on a scapegoat. In *Je vois Satan tomber comme l'éclair* (1999) he identified Satan not with a person but with this process itself—the mimetic cycle of rivalry, contagion, and expulsion. In *Achever Clausewitz* (2007) he read the apocalyptic texts as descriptions of Clausewitz's escalation to extremes, the logic by which reciprocal violence, unchecked, tends toward totality.

The Great Evil of *The Fifth Element* is Girard's Satan rendered as a celestial body. It does not merely tolerate violence; it is violence's cumulative form, and every attempt to destroy it by force feeds its escalation. The military's strategy is mimetic: answer the threat with greater force. The result is a larger Evil. The film's cosmic ethics therefore converge with the tradition of nonviolence that runs from Paul's exhortation to overcome evil with good (Romans 12:21) through Tolstoy's *The Kingdom of God Is Within You* (1894) to Martin Luther King Jr., who preached in *Strength to Love* (1963) that "hate cannot drive out hate; only love can do that."

The film is not consistently pacifist. Leeloo dispatches Mangalores with balletic violence, and the action genre requires its fights. But the film's ethics are stratified. At the human scale, force can delay, defend, and protect. At the cosmic scale, force is self-defeating, because the adversary is the sum of force itself. Only an act that exits the mimetic economy altogether—an act that is not a counter-blow but a gift—can stop the escalation. Zorg, who believes that destruction creates life, serves an entity that is nothing but the accumulated destruction of life. The film's answer to both is a gesture neither of them can imitate.



Chapter VI

The Archive of Catastrophe

Leeloo, the Encyclopedia, and the Problem of Evil

The philosophical crisis of *The Fifth Element* occurs not in the temple but at a screen. Over the course of the film Leeloo educates herself by ingesting a digital encyclopedia of human civilisation in alphabetical order, at a speed no human reader could match. In its final movement, wounded and travelling back toward Earth, she reaches the letter W and the entry for War: documentary footage of twentieth-century warfare, culminating in the nuclear fireball. She is found in tears, and when the decisive moment arrives in the temple she asks why life should be saved when human beings do with it what she has seen. This chapter argues that the scene restages the Fall with the deity in the place of the creature, poses the problem of evil in the inverted form of an *anthropodicy*, and situates the film's Supreme Being in the theology that followed Auschwitz.

VI.1 The Alphabet's Cruelty: L Before W

The alphabetical order of Leeloo's reading is not a neutral device. It means that she passes the entry for Love long before she reaches the entry for War. When, at the climax, she says that she does not know love, the claim cannot mean that she lacks information about it. She has read everything

the archive contains on the subject. What she lacks is not knowledge *about* love but knowledge *of* it.

Bertrand Russell's distinction between knowledge by description and knowledge by acquaintance (1910–1911) names the gap; Frank Jackson's knowledge argument names its stakes. In "Epiphenomenal Qualia" (1982) and "What Mary Didn't Know" (1986), Jackson imagined Mary, a neuroscientist who knows every physical fact about colour vision but has lived all her life in a black-and-white room; when she first sees red, Jackson argued, she learns something new—what it is like—which no quantity of descriptive information could have supplied. Leeloo is Mary in the encyclopedic room. Her informational surplus, certified in Chapter IV by the scientist's inventory of her genome, is complete; and it is precisely complete information that leaves her without the one acquaintance the plot requires.

The asymmetry is crueller still, because the archive does not treat its two entries equally. War is documentable: it leaves footage, ruins, casualty tables, a visual record that can be streamed into an eye at speed. Love leaves almost nothing of the kind; it is the least archivable of human realities, existing chiefly in acts between persons that no camera captures and no encyclopedia can transmit. The archive is therefore structurally biased toward catastrophe. Leeloo learns about love by description and about war by something close to acquaintance, because the medium of her learning—moving images—can deliver the one and not the other. The film's theory of the archive is that it tells the truth about human beings in the form most likely to make them seem unworthy of salvation.

Archive Fever VI.2

Jacques Derrida's *Mal d'archive* (1995), published while the film was in production, argued that the archive is haunted by the death drive Freud described in *Beyond the Pleasure Principle*: every archive, in preserving, also destroys, selects, and forgets, and the passion to archive is inseparable from a drive toward annihilation. Leeloo's archive literalises the thesis. It culminates, alphabetically and historically, in the record of humanity's self-destruction; and its effect on its reader is to transmit that drive—to make a being created for the preservation of life doubt whether life should be preserved. The archive is not a neutral repository but an agent. It nearly ac-

complishes what the Great Evil could not, by persuading the fifth element to decline her function.

The encyclopedic form has a French genealogy of its own. The *Encyclopédie* of Diderot and d'Alembert (1751–1772) proposed to gather all human knowledge and, in Diderot's words in the article "Encyclopédie" (1755), to change the common way of thinking. D'Alembert's *Discours préliminaire* (1751) organised that knowledge on a systematic *arbre encyclopédique*—a tree of knowledge—while the volumes themselves followed the democratic, arbitrary order of the alphabet. The Enlightenment's confidence was that total knowledge would liberate. Jorge Luis Borges supplied the century's counter-fables: Funes, in "Funes el memorioso" (1942), remembers everything and can therefore think nothing, since thought requires forgetting differences; the Library of Babel (1941) contains every possible book and is therefore a labyrinth of despair. Leeloo is neither enlightened by the encyclopedia nor paralysed by it in Funes's way. She understands it, and understanding is what wounds her.

Borges supplied a third fable that bears on Leeloo's archive more directly. In "El idioma analítico de John Wilkins" (1942) he cited a fictitious Chinese encyclopedia whose animals fall into absurd classes—those belonging to the Emperor, embalmed ones, and so on. Michel Foucault opened *Les Mots et les choses* (1966) with the laughter this list provoked in him, a laughter that exposed the historical contingency of every order of knowledge. Leeloo's archive has an order too, the alphabet, and the form of its verdict is partly an artefact of that order: she meets Love as a word long before she meets War as images. The indictment is not thereby false. But its apparent finality belongs to the arrangement of the archive as much as to the history the archive records.

VI.3 The Fall of God

The structure is Edenic. In Genesis 2–3, the creature, innocent and unashamed of her nakedness, eats of the tree of the knowledge of good and evil and falls into shame, toil, and death. Leeloo enters the film innocent and unashamed of her nakedness (Chapter IV); she eats—with an appetite the film elsewhere makes comic—of the *arbre encyclopédique*; and the knowledge of evil it gives her produces not shame but grief so profound

that it threatens her capacity to act. The difference is that in *The Fifth Element* it is the deity who eats. The Fall is not the creature's but the creator's, and it is a fall into knowledge of the creature.

The Easter *Exsultet* sings of Adam's sin as a happy fault (*felix culpa*) that merited so great a Redeemer. The film's inversion is exact: the deity's fall merits a redeemer, and the redeemer is a human being. Chapter IX develops the consequences of this reversal—the redemption of the redeemer—which Wagner placed as the final words of *Parsifal*.

The biblical wisdom literature had already diagnosed the condition into which Leeloo falls. "For in much wisdom is much grief: and he that increaseth knowledge increaseth sorrow" (Ecclesiastes 1:18). And Paul's hymn to love supplies the diagnosis of her paralysis with uncanny precision: "though I have the gift of prophecy, and understand all mysteries, and all knowledge ... and have not charity, I am nothing" (1 Corinthians 13:2). Leeloo understands all knowledge; she is, at the decisive moment, nothing —an inert body among inert stones—until charity is supplied.

Melencolia VI.4

The iconographic analogue is Albrecht Dürer's engraving *Melencolia I* (1514). A winged genius sits amid the instruments of knowledge—compass, sphere, polyhedron, scales, hourglass, bell, magic square—head propped on hand, eyes dark with an inward gaze, wings folded and useless. Raymond Klibansky, Erwin Panofsky, and Fritz Saxl (1964) read the figure as the melancholy of the creative intellect that has measured everything and can no longer act: genius arrested by its own knowledge. Leeloo after the archive is Dürer's genius in a spaceship: a winged being, in the sense that matters, surrounded by the totality of human knowledge and unable to rise. That the engraving's polyhedron has often been read as a Platonic solid, and its magic square as an emblem of Jupiter set against Saturn's melancholy, places the image within the cosmological tradition reconstructed in Chapter I. The fifth element, like Dürer's genius, is paralysed by the very completeness of its knowledge of the four.

VI.5 From Theodicy to Anthropodicy

The classical problem of evil asks whether God can be justified in the face of the world's suffering. Leeloo's question inverts it. She does not ask whether God is just, given the world; she asks whether humanity is worth saving, given what humanity does. The film's problem is an *anthropodicy*: the justification of the human before the divine.

The question nonetheless descends from the most powerful modern formulation of the classical problem. In Book V, chapter 4 ("Rebellion") of *The Brothers Karamazov* (1880), Ivan tells his brother Alyosha that he accepts God but not God's world; that no future harmony could justify the suffering of a single tortured child; and that he therefore respectfully returns his ticket. Leeloo, having read the archive, stands at Ivan's threshold from the other side: she is the one who could issue the ticket to a future, and she is tempted to withhold it. Ursula K. Le Guin's "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973) imagines a utopia whose happiness depends on the misery of one child and the citizens who, learning of it, simply walk away. Leeloo nearly walks away from Earth.

The anthropodicy, as the film frames it, contains a second category mistake parallel to the first. Leeloo indicts "humanity" as though it were a single agent, as Ryle's visitor sought the University as though it were one more building. Hannah Arendt, reflecting on the Eichmann trial (1963) and on personal responsibility under dictatorship (1964), warned that where all are said to be guilty, no one is: the indictment of a collective dissolves the responsibility of the persons who acted. The archive Leeloo reads does not record what humanity did. It records what particular states, regimes, armies, and persons did to particular victims, while others resisted or rescued. And it records the victims themselves. Etty Hillesum's diary, discussed below, belongs to the same archive as the footage of war; the answer the film seeks is not wholly absent from the record, and one of the places it is written is the testimony of a murdered woman. The archive is biased toward catastrophe, but it is not silent about love. It holds love chiefly as testimony, which images cannot carry.

Albert Camus opened *Le Mythe de Sisyphe* (1942) with the statement that there is only one truly serious philosophical problem, and that it is suicide; to judge *que la vie vaut ou ne vaut pas la peine d'être vécue*—whether

life is or is not worth living—is, he wrote, to answer the fundamental question of philosophy. Leeloo poses Camus's question at the scale of a species and from the position of the one being who can decide it. Her temptation is not to end her own life but to withhold the act without which every life on Earth will end: she is asked whether a species that does what the archive shows deserves to go on existing, and she alone can answer by deed. Camus's answer was revolt: lucid persistence in the absurd without appeal, so that one must imagine Sisyphus happy. He also named, and rejected, what he called philosophical suicide (*le suicide philosophique*): the leap by which Kierkegaard, Chestov, and Jaspers escaped the absurd into a transcendence that reason could not warrant. In *La Peste* (1947) his doctor, Rieux, fights the plague not out of faith but out of a decency (*honnêteté*) he declines to theorise. Korben's answer resembles Rieux's in its refusal of theory, and Chapter IX must face the Camusian objection that it is nonetheless a leap. The reply given there is that Korben appeals to nothing beyond the world. He does not ask Leeloo to believe that the archive is redeemed elsewhere; he asks her to receive a love, here, that the archive could not record.

After Auschwitz: A God Who Must Be Helped VI.6

The archive Leeloo reads is the archive of the twentieth century, and the theology most directly relevant to her crisis is the theology that century produced after its central catastrophe. In his lecture "Der Gottesbegriff nach Auschwitz" (delivered 1984, published 1987), Hans Jonas argued that after Auschwitz one cannot hold together divine omnipotence, divine goodness, and the intelligibility of God; the attribute that must be surrendered is omnipotence. Jonas proposed, in the form of a myth, a God who in creating had renounced his power and given himself over to the becoming of the world, a God who suffers, becomes, and cares, and who therefore depends on human beings. It is not God who can help us, his argument concludes, but we who must help God.

Jonas's myth has a documentary precursor in the diaries of Etty Hillesum, a young Jewish woman in occupied Amsterdam whom the German occupation authorities deported from the Westerbork transit camp to Auschwitz on 7 September 1943, with her parents and her brother Mischa, and who was murdered there; the Red Cross later recorded her date of

death as 30 November 1943. On 12 July 1942 she wrote a prayer telling God that it had become clear to her that He could not help them, and that *we must help You to help ourselves*. The inversion is total: the believer resolves to protect, within herself, the God who cannot protect her.

The Supreme Being of *The Fifth Element* is Jonas's God given a body. She is not omnipotent: she can be shot, wounded, exhausted, and, above all, discouraged. She is affected by the world, and what affects her most is the record of a century in which the SS of Nazi Germany murdered some 1.1 million people at Auschwitz-Birkenau, about a million of them Jews, within a genocide that killed some six million European Jews, and in which the United States destroyed Hiroshima and Nagasaki with atomic bombs in August 1945, killing an estimated 200,000 people, most of them civilians, by the end of that year. And she cannot act alone: at the moment of decision she depends on a human being to supply what her own nature, informationally plenary and morally overwhelmed, cannot. Korben's declaration is the act Hillesum described—a human being helping God to help us.

VI.7 The Angel of History and the Weak Messianic Power

Walter Benjamin's ninth thesis "On the Concept of History" (1940), written months before his death at Portbou, describes Paul Klee's *Angelus Novus* as the angel of history. His face is turned toward the past. Where we perceive a chain of events, he sees one single catastrophe that keeps piling wreckage upon wreckage at his feet. He would like to stay, awaken the dead, and make whole what has been smashed. But a storm is blowing from Paradise; it has caught in his wings with such violence that he can no longer close them, and it propels him irresistibly into the future to which his back is turned. This storm, Benjamin writes, is what we call progress.

Leeloo before the screen is Benjamin's angel. Her face is turned to the archive of the past; she sees not a sequence of historical episodes but a single catastrophe; she would make whole what has been smashed, for that is the function for which she was made; and she is borne toward a future she cannot face. The film even supplies the storm from Paradise: she reaches W in flight from *Fhloston Paradise*, a luxury resort that has just been consumed

by explosions—the bourgeois paradise of the future destroyed by the very economy of destruction that Zorg called life.

Benjamin's second thesis supplies what the ninth lacks. Every generation, he wrote, is endowed with a *weak* messianic power, to which the past has a claim. The redemption of history is not the work of a sovereign messiah arriving from outside but of a modest, distributed power in each human generation. Korben's act in the temple is a weak messianic power in exactly this sense: not a miracle, not a weapon, not a cosmic intervention, but the smallest possible human act—three words and a kiss—on which the past's claim to redemption and the future's possibility both depend.

The Spectator Who Is Still Wounded VI.8

Susan Sontag's *On Photography* (1977) worried that the proliferation of images of atrocity anaesthetises their viewers; her *Regarding the Pain of Others* (2003) partly retracted the worry, insisting that images of suffering can still haunt, though they cannot by themselves explain or redeem. Luc Boltanski's *La Souffrance à distance* (1993) analysed the moral positions available to the spectator of distant suffering—denunciation, sentiment, aesthetic contemplation—and the politics of pity they sustain. Jean Baudrillard's *La Guerre du Golfe n'a pas eu lieu* (1991) argued, provocatively, that a war experienced as a televised simulation had ceased to be an event at all.

Leeloo is the spectator who refutes Baudrillard and confirms the later Sontag. She experiences war only as images, and the images wound her absolutely; mediation does not empty the real of its moral weight. But she also exposes the limit of the spectator's position that Boltanski described. The archive can produce pity, horror, even despair; it cannot produce the act that would answer them. The spectator's sentiment, however intense, remains at a distance. What the film requires is the abolition of that distance—a relation in which the one who suffers and the one who responds are present to each other. That is why the answer to the archive cannot come from the archive.

VI.9 Jung's Job and the Conscience of God

C. G. Jung's *Antwort auf Hiob* (1952) read the Book of Job as the moment at which God, confronted by the moral integrity of a creature he has tormented, is forced into an awareness of his own shadow; the incarnation, for Jung, is God's attempt to catch up with the moral consciousness that his creature has already attained. The film transposes Jung's drama. Its God, confronted not by the integrity but by the depravity of her creatures, becomes conscious of evil through them; and it is a creature who must supply what she lacks. In both Jung and the film the relation between God and the human is reciprocal and developmental. The divine does not simply judge humanity; it is changed by encountering it, and completed by it.

The archive scene therefore states the problem to which the remainder of the film is the answer. The problem is not that the Supreme Being lacks information; she has all of it. The problem is that information about human beings, assembled in the form an archive can hold, constitutes an indictment, and that no further information can overturn it. The answer, if there is one, must be of a different order than knowledge. Chapter IX names that order.



Chapter VII

Spectacle, Carnival, Camp

The Sociocosmic Tetrasomia and the Politics of Laughter

Chapters IV through VI anatomised the film's principal persons. This chapter anatomises its institutions and its tone, and advances two claims. The first is structural: the film distributes the four classical elements across the four institutional powers of late modernity—the territorial state, the armaments economy, broadcast media, and the spectacle of art—so that its cosmology is also a sociology. This redistribution is here called the *sociocosmic tetrasomia*. The second claim is tonal: the film's carnivalesque register, its camp, and its comedy are not lapses of seriousness but the instruments by which its seriousness survives.

The Sociocosmic Tetrasomia

VII.1

The coinage joins Greek *tetra-* and *sōma*, "four bodies." The Greek alchemical corpus used *tetrasōmia* for the four base metals—the "bodies" awaiting transmutation—and the alchemical sense is apt. The four institutions of the film are base bodies that cannot transmute themselves. Each commands one element of collective life; each attempts to seize, contain, sell, or broadcast the fifth; each fails; and at the climax each element is reclaimed from its institution by a humble act of a human body.

VII.1

The Sociocosmic Tetrasomia

Element

Earth

Institution

The territorial state (the Federated Territories)

Principal figures

President Lindberg, the generals, the police

Mode of power

Sovereignty, containment, force

Characteristic failure

Its fire enlarges the Evil; it holds the god for minutes

How its stone is opened

A handful of sand

Element

Fire

Institution

The armaments economy

Principal figures

Zorg, the Mangalores, the ZF-1

Mode of power

Production and sale of destruction

Characteristic failure

Consumed by its own detonations

How its stone is opened

A last match

Element

The fifth

Institution

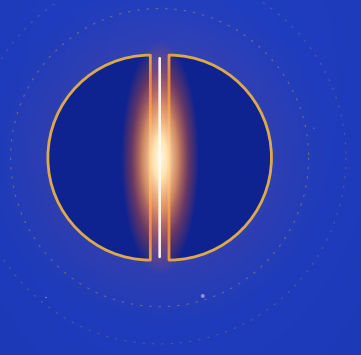
None

Principal figures

Korben and Leeloo

Mode of power

Relation



Characteristic failure

Cannot be administered, produced, broadcast, or performed

How its stone is opened

A declaration and a kiss

Element

Air

Institution

Broadcast media

Principal figures

Ruby Rhod

Mode of power

Circulation of voice through the airwaves

Characteristic failure

Converts catastrophe into programming

How its stone is opened

Breath

Element

Water

Institution

Art as spectacle

Principal figures

The Diva Plavalaguna

Mode of power

Beauty, voice, the bearing of what is precious

Characteristic failure

Martyred: it carries the stones and dies

How its stone is opened

Sweat

The table's last column is its argument. In every case the stone is opened not by the institution that claimed the element but by a gesture that any human body can perform: scooping, striking, breathing, sweating. The institutions monopolise the elements in their social form; the climax returns them to their bodily form. And the fifth row has no institution at all.

Earth: The Territorial State VII.2

The polity of the film is named for land: the Federated Territories. Carl Schmitt's *Der Nomos der Erde* (1950) located the origin of every legal order in a land-appropriation (*Landnahme*), a founding division of the earth; in its archaic self-understanding the state is the order of earth. The film's state exhibits every function of territorial sovereignty. It polices movement through identity cards, checkpoints, and an automated raid on Korben's apartment; it contains bodies in the laboratory cell; it answers threats with force. Each function fails at the decisive scale. Its warship nourishes the Evil; its containment holds the god for minutes; its intelligence apparatus must rig a pet-food contest to dispatch its agent.

The state is not villainous. Its President is anxious, decent, and open to counsel; he consults the priest, as Habermas's later account of the post-secular society (2001) would recommend that secular institutions learn from religious traditions whose semantic resources they cannot generate. But the state's earth is inert soil. Its stone is opened by a handful of sand—earth as such, carried in a hand and stripped of territory.

Terry Gilliam's *Brazil* (1985) had imagined the bureaucratic state from below. Its clerk, Sam Lowry, dreams of flight; at the end the state's Ministry of Information tortures him, and his escape survives only as a hallucination. *The Fifth Element* reverses the figure. Its god falls into the state rather than flying out of it, and escapes it in fact: the state's containment fails, and its salvation is decided in a room it does not control.

Fire: The Armaments Economy VII.3

Zorg Industries, anatomised in Chapter V, is the element of fire in its Promethean-industrial form: combustion turned to production and production turned to destruction. Its showpiece weapon throws flame; its owner dies in an explosion; its emblem is the detonation. The fire stone

is opened by the most modest flame imaginable, a single match kept by a man trying to stop smoking. The film thus separates fire from industry and returns it to its Promethean origin—not a commodity but a gift, hoarded against an hour of need.

VII.4 Air: Ruby Rhod and the Counterfeit Ether

Ruby Rhod, the radio host played by Chris Tucker, is the element of air: a voice transmitted through the airwaves, breathless, shrieking, hyperventilating, ubiquitous. His show turns the voyage to *Fhloston Paradise* into a live entertainment, and when the Mangalores attack he continues to broadcast, terrified, converting catastrophe into programming. Max Horkheimer and Theodor Adorno's chapter on the culture industry in *Dialektik der Aufklärung* (1947) described amusement under late capitalism as the prolongation of work and the endless deferral of the pleasure it promises. Guy Debord's *La Société du spectacle* (1967) defined the spectacle, in its fourth thesis, as *un rapport social entre des personnes, médiatisé par des images*—a social relation among persons, mediated by images. Ruby is the spectacle given a body.

Jean Baudrillard's *Simulacres et simulation* (1981) described a "precession of simulacra" in which the model precedes and produces the real it claims to represent. Ruby's broadcast has this structure. The voyage is staged as a programme before it happens, and the attack, as he narrates it, arrives already formatted as content.

His mythological type is Hermes: messenger, trickster, patron of commerce and thieves, guide of travellers and of souls. Hermes is also, in Ovid (*Metamorphoses* IV), the father by Aphrodite of Hermaphroditus, and Ruby's flamboyant androgyny belongs to the same figure. He is the herald degraded into a huckster, but also a psychopomp: he accompanies Korben through the underworld of the attack and, against all expectation, emerges alive.

The celebration of Ruby as trickster requires a qualification. Ruby is one of the film's few Black characters, and his comedy draws on a long Hollywood repertoire in which Black men were cast as hysterical, cowardly, or hypersexual figures of fun, a repertoire Donald Bogle catalogued in *Toms, Coons, Mulattoes, Mammies, and Bucks* (1973); his flamboyance

draws equally on the tradition, traced by Vito Russo in *The Celluloid Closet* (1981), in which queerness was signified as comic excess. Chris Tucker's performance is virtuosic, and the film's President, also Black, is written with dignity. But the carnival laughs at Ruby more than with him. Bakhtin's carnival laughed at power; a carnival whose laughter falls on a figure already marginal does not defeat cosmic terror but displaces it onto a stereotype. The corollary of the carnivalesque sublime (Chapter IX.5) holds only with that limit marked.

Ruby's element yields the chapter's sharpest irony. The *aether* of Aristotle, the fifth body of the heavens, survived into nineteenth-century physics as the luminiferous ether, the hypothetical medium through which light and electromagnetic waves were thought to travel. Michelson and Morley failed to detect it in 1887; Einstein made it superfluous in 1905. But it survived in the idiom of broadcasting, which still speaks of programmes going out "over the ether." The broadcast media thus inherited the very name of the quintessence, and with it the Ficinian claim to be the medium that connects all things. Ruby Rhod is the counterfeit quintessence: a medium that connects everyone and relates no one. His ether carries voices to millions, but no voice in it is addressed to anyone in particular. It is mediation without relation—Debord's spectacle exactly. The true medium, the film will show, carries one sentence to one person.

Water: The Diva, Art, and Martyrdom VII.5

The Diva Plavalaguna—"blue lagoon"—is the element of water: azure, fluid, carrying within her body what is most precious. She is played by Maïwenn and sung by the Albanian soprano Inva Mula, and her recital begins with "Il dolce suono," the mad scene of Donizetti's *Lucia di Lammermoor* (1835; libretto by Salvadore Cammarano after Walter Scott's *The Bride of Lammermoor*, 1819). The choice is exact. Lucia, forced into marriage with a man she does not love, has killed her bridegroom on the wedding night; in her madness she imagines her wedding to her true beloved. The aria is the song of a union that is a death. The Diva sings the failed wedding before the film stages its successful one.

The Romantic culmination of this form is the *Liebestod* with which Isolde ends Wagner's *Tristan und Isolde* (1865): love consummated in

death, union achieved by leaving the world. Donizetti's opera ends in the same key, with Edgardo taking his own life to be joined with Lucia. The Diva's aria belongs to that genre, and her own death completes it. The film's climax inverts it. Its lovers are united so that the world may continue, and their consummation preserves life rather than abolishing it.

The aria then dissolves into Éric Serra's "Diva Dance," in which coloratura becomes an electronic dance line whose agility the film presents as exceeding any human voice. The fusion of opera and club music stages a dialectic Walter Benjamin described in "Das Kunstwerk im Zeitalter seiner technischen Reproduzierbarkeit" (1935–1936). The Diva is aura incarnate —unique, present, unrepeatable, like Beineix's soprano who refused to be recorded—and yet her voice arrives processed by the machinery of reproduction. The film refuses Benjamin's choice between aura and reproduction. It makes the sacred voice electronic and the electronic voice sacred.

The recital is intercut with Leeloo's combat against the Mangalores in the Diva's quarters, so that each beat of the music lands as a blow. Benjamin's epilogue to the same essay warned that a humanity whose self-alienation had reached a certain degree could experience its own destruction as an aesthetic pleasure of the first order. The montage invites precisely that pleasure—violence as choreography—and then punctures it. The Diva is shot. The aestheticised violence becomes the real death of the artist. The film stages its own aestheticism and interrupts it with a corpse.

The Diva is a martyr in the etymological sense: a witness (*martys*). Dying, she delivers the stones from inside her body and names, for Korben, what Leeloo needs—his help and his love. Her body is a reliquary, and the gesture with which the stones pass from her body into a human hand has a Eucharistic shape: the body that gives what saves. She is also the only figure before the climax who knows the answer. The state, the economy, and the media never learn what the fifth element requires; art knows it and dies for carrying it. Shelley's *Defence of Poetry* (written 1821) called poets the unacknowledged legislators of the world. The Diva is the unacknowledged prophet of the film.

Her element is reclaimed at the climax by sweat. Genesis 3:19 makes sweat the sign of the Fall: in the sweat of thy face shalt thou eat bread. In the temple, the sweat of a human brow opens the stone of water. The curse becomes a sacrament; the bodily residue of labour and fear becomes the

medium of salvation. The Diva's blue lagoon and the human brow are, in the film's economy, the same water.

Gaultier and the Ontology of the Surface VII.6

Jean Paul Gaultier's costumes are the film's most celebrated surface and the evidence most often cited for its superficiality. Charles Baudelaire's "Le Peintre de la vie moderne" (1863) supplies the corrective. Modernity, Baudelaire wrote, is *le transitoire, le fugitif, le contingent*—the transitory, the fugitive, the contingent—which is half of art, the other half being the eternal and immutable. *The Fifth Element* is Baudelairean in structure: Gaultier supplies the fugitive half, the cosmology the eternal half, and the film's wager is that the eternal can be carried only in the clothes of the moment.

Benjamin's fourteenth thesis on history credited fashion with a flair for the topical wherever it stirs in the thickets of the past, and called it a tiger's leap (*Tigersprung*) into what has been. Gaultier's future is a tissue of such leaps: mummy wrappings, Breton stripes, Baroque ruffs, mid-century air-hostess uniforms, fetish latex, couture parodies of fast-food livery. The Mondoshawans' brass armour, which resembles antique diving suits, carries the director's own biography into the costume: Besson, the son of diving instructors, whose first ambition was marine biology. Roland Barthes's *Système de la mode* (1967) treated fashion as a system of signs, and the film's costumes signify institutions as precisely as uniforms do—the police, the airline, the restaurant, the broadcaster, the opera.

The film's palette is a theology of colour. The Evil is black; Leeloo emerges in white bandages and finally as white light; her hair is the orange-red of flame; the Diva is blue. Read through the alchemical opus that Jung reconstructed in *Psychologie und Alchemie* (1944), the sequence is legible as *nigredo*, *albedo*, and *rubedo*: the blackening of chaos, the whitening of purification, the reddening of union. The Great Work ends in the *coniunctio*, the conjunction of opposites that produces the stone. The interpretation does not require Gaultier or Besson to have intended it. The colours are pre-constrained elements, in Lévi-Strauss's sense, and they carry their history.

VII.7 Carnival: The Defeat of Cosmic Terror

Mikhail Bakhtin's *Rabelais and His World* (written in 1940, published in Russian in 1965) argued that medieval carnival laughter was a popular victory over fear: fear of the sacred, of authority, of death, and of cosmic catastrophe. Carnival presented the terrible in droll and monstrous form; it uncrowned kings, inverted hierarchies, and celebrated the grotesque body —open, eating, drinking, excreting, choking—and the material bodily lower stratum. Bakhtin's point was not that carnival distracts from terror but that it defeats it, by rendering the cosmos a body that laughs.

The Fifth Element stages the end of the world as carnival. Its tyrant is uncrowned by a cherry. Its hero is harassed by his mother's telephone calls while the planet is threatened. Its cigarettes are almost entirely filter. Its fast-food restaurant flies. Its mercenaries have the faces of dogs; its singer has tentacles; its broadcaster shrieks. The film's tonal heterogeneity—slapstick within apocalypse—has been read as incoherence. In Bakhtin's terms it is the people's response to cosmic terror, and France is the homeland of the tradition Bakhtin analysed. Rabelais's giants, with their appetites and their battles, stand behind Besson's carnival as surely as Champollion stands behind his temple.

A Sanskrit homophony, which need not have been intended, names the theology of this carnival. In Vedāntic and Vaiṣṇava thought the creation is *līlā*, the play of God: the *Brahmasūtra* (2.1.33) answers the question why a self-sufficient deity would create at all by saying that creation is sport, as in the world. A heroine called Leeloo, whose divinity is childlike, appetitive, and delighted by the world it has come to save, is a figure of *līlā*, and laughter is the register in which such a theology can be told.

VII.8 Camp, Sincerity, and the Carnivalesque Sublime

Susan Sontag's "Notes on 'Camp'" (1964) defined camp as a love of artifice and exaggeration, distinguished naive camp, which fails at seriousness, from deliberate camp, which plays at it, and assigned to camp the project to *dethrone the serious*. *The Fifth Element* is deliberate camp throughout—and its climax is not dethroned. When Korben speaks to Leeloo in the temple, the film suspends its irony entirely. The declaration of love is delivered without a wink.

This matters because the film appeared at the height of what Fredric Jameson (1991) diagnosed as the postmodern "waning of affect," and of what David Foster Wallace's "E Unibus Pluram" (1993) called the tyranny of irony in American culture. Wallace imagined a coming generation of "anti-rebels" willing to risk sentimentality and to treat plain human emotions with reverence and conviction. *The Fifth Element* is an early instance of the strategy later called the New Sincerity: it surrounds its sincerity with so much camp that irony has nothing left to attack. Milan Kundera's *The Unbearable Lightness of Being* (1984) defined kitsch as the absolute denial of the body's indignities and located it in a second tear—the tear shed at being moved together with all mankind. The film escapes kitsch for a Bakhtinian reason. Its sincerity coexists with the cherry, the filter cigarettes, and Ruby's screaming; it never denies the grotesque body, and so its tears are first tears only.

The film's Evil, meanwhile, is a figure of the sublime. Kant's *Kritik der Urteilskraft* (1790, §§23–29) located the sublime in objects of overwhelming magnitude or might and noted that it can be found even in formless objects; Burke's *Philosophical Enquiry* (1757) grounded it in terror. Jean-François Lyotard (1982) defined the postmodern sublime as the presentation of the unpresentable, and Scott Bukatman (1995) identified in science-fiction cinema an "artificial infinite," a special-effects sublime of vast cities and cosmic objects. The Evil—an amorphous mass of darkness and fire larger than a planet—is the film's unpresentable. What the film adds is the conjunction of this sublime with carnival. The *carnivalesque sublime* presents the unpresentable and disarms it in the same gesture: it makes cosmic terror visible and laughable at once, so that the spectator can bear to look at the end of the world long enough to see how it might be averted.

Gender: The *Femme-enfant*, the Gaze, and the Interval VII.9

The Bessonian heroine—Nikita, Mathilda, Leeloo, Joan, Lucy—is a lethal innocent, and her most important literary ancestor is French. In *Arcane 17*, written in 1944 on the Gaspé coast and published in 1945, André Breton named the *femme-enfant*, the child-woman, as the being through whom a world devastated by war might be regenerated; the seventeenth arcanum

of the Tarot, the Star, was his emblem of hope rising after catastrophe, and Breton declared that the time had come to value the ideas of woman over those of man. Leeloo is the *femme-enfant* raised to divinity. Xavière Gauthier's *Surréalisme et sexualité* (1971) answered Breton with the feminist objection that applies equally to Besson: the child-woman is a male projection, innocence and power dreamed by men.

The objection has force. The regeneration sequence, as Chapter IV showed, organises the female body as spectacle for a male gaze (Mulvey 1975). Leeloo is made by men, rescued by a man, and activated by a man's declaration. Her martial power is real—she defeats the Mangalores single-handed, and belongs with the action heroines Carol Clover (1992) and Yvonne Tasker (1993) analysed—but her divine power awaits a male sentence. Korben, meanwhile, is a softened version of what Susan Jeffords (1994) called the "hard bodies" of Reagan-era cinema: a decorated soldier who has stopped fighting, drives a cab, lives alone with a cat, and is nagged by his mother. His arc runs from war to love.

The objection has a biographical edge that should be stated rather than left implicit. *Léon* (1994) frames the bond between a hitman and a twelve-year-old girl with romantic undertones that critics have long found troubling. Maïwenn, who plays the Diva, began a relationship with Besson when, by widely reported accounts, she was fifteen and he was in his early thirties; they married in 1992, and their daughter was born in 1993. A relationship between a man in his thirties and a girl of fifteen is not a matter of taste; it is the harm that the *femme-enfant* fantasy disguises. The film's Supreme Being is an adult woman, and the argument of this dissertation does not depend on its director's life. But the critique of the child-woman as a male projection applies to Besson's oeuvre with particular force, and the Diva, whose death the plot requires, is played by Maïwenn.

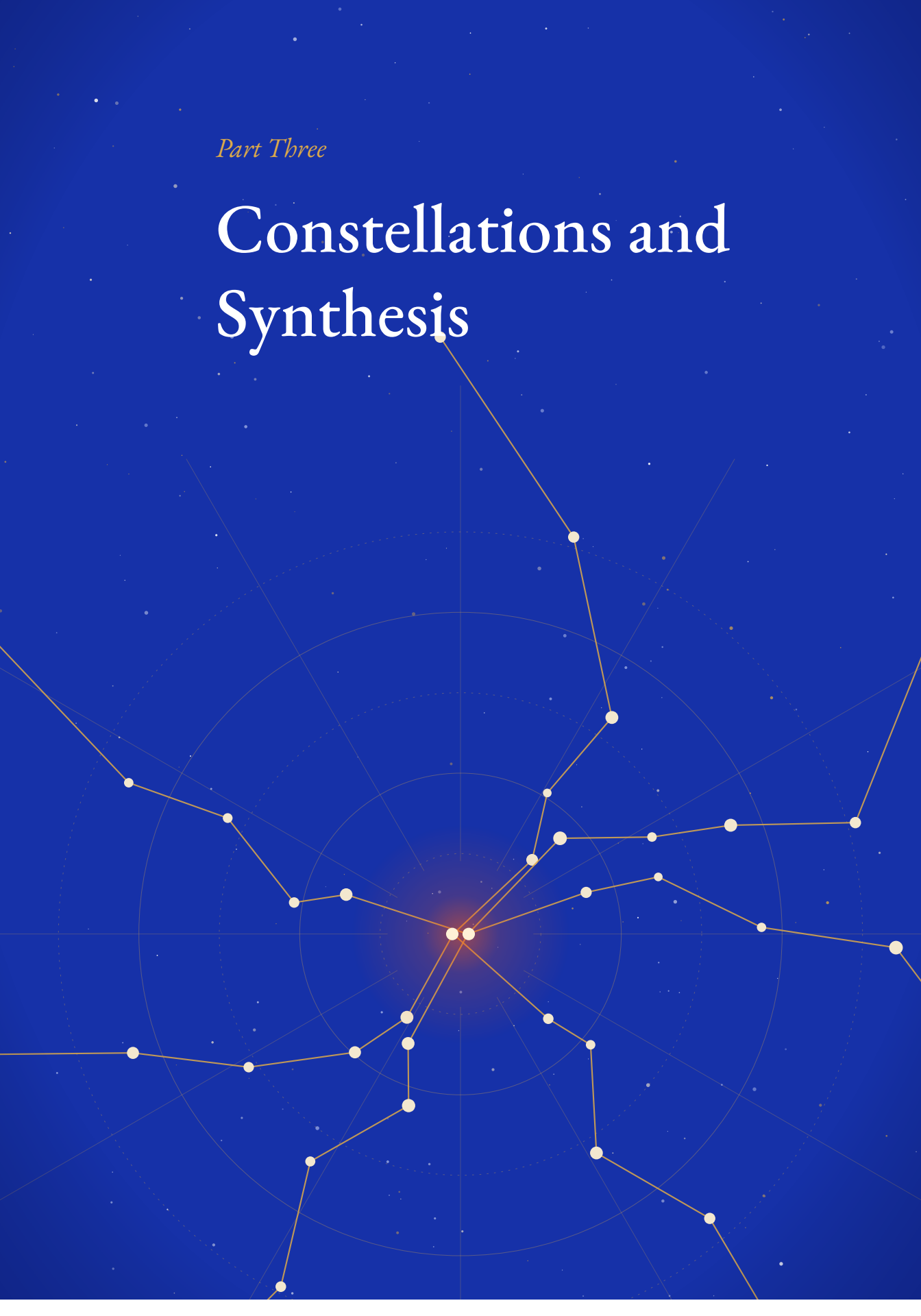
Feminist theology sharpens the stakes. Mary Daly's *Beyond God the Father* (1973) argued that "if God is male, then the male is God." The film's Supreme Being is female, and in that respect it answers Daly. Luce Irigaray's "Femmes divines" (1984; collected in *Sexes et parentés*, 1987) argued that women require a divine in their own gender in order to become subjects; the film supplies one. But Irigaray's *Éthique de la différence sexuelle* (1984) offers a more searching frame. There Irigaray located the divine neither in the male nor in the female but in the interval between them, a *transcendan-*

tal sensible—a sensible transcendental—generated in and through sexual difference rather than above it. The film's final image fits Irigaray's figure with uncanny precision. The divine light does not issue from Leeloo alone, nor from Korben, but from the interval of their embrace.

The asymmetry does not vanish: he speaks, she receives. And the man who speaks at the climax is the man who earlier kissed her while she was unconscious, a non-consensual act that the narrative never reckons with (Chapter IV.2). The film half-corrects itself: her first translated words establish that nothing may be done to her without her permission, and the final kiss is one she returns. But it never stages that permission being given, and it asks the audience to accept its hero as the bearer of salvific love without asking him to answer for the earlier act. The distribution of power partly offsets the imbalance: the light is hers, and his declaration confers nothing on her except the will to use what she already has. The verdict must be mixed, and harder than a first reading suggests. The film is not innocent of the gaze, of male tutelage, or of treating an assault as a comic beat. Its metaphysics points beyond its gender politics: the fifth element is in neither sex but between them, and Chapter VIII shows the same structure realised, two years later, with its genders reversed. But a theology of the interval is only as good as the respect it requires for the person on the other side of it, and on this point the film's practice falls short of its theory.

Part Three

Constellations and Synthesis





Chapter VIII

Comparative Constellations

The Film among Speculative, Mythological, and Philosophical Fictions

Every work that imagines the end of a world must also imagine what averts it, and the answers fall into a small number of types. A world may be saved by *transcendence*, an evolutionary leap that leaves the human behind; by *gnosis*, a knowledge that liberates; by *force and sacrifice*, a weapon or a death; or by *relation*, a bond between persons. This chapter places *The Fifth Element* among cognate fictions and non-fictions under Jonathan Z. Smith's discipline: each comparison is chosen to clarify the film's answer to that single question. The result is that the film emerges as the most fully elaborated relational soteriology in the popular science fiction of its decade.

Transcendence without Relation: Clarke, Kubrick, Lem, Tarkovsky

VIII.1

Arthur C. Clarke's *Childhood's End* (1953) is the canonical fiction of benevolent alien stewardship. The Overlords, who resemble devils, arrive to end war and shepherd humanity's children toward union with the Overmind, a cosmic intelligence; the children transcend, the parents are left behind, and the Earth dissolves. Salvation is evolutionary absorption, and love is not merely irrelevant but an attachment the transcendence must

sever. Stanley Kubrick and Clarke's *2001: A Space Odyssey* (1968) repeats the structure: an alien monolith presides over evolutionary leaps, and the film ends with the Star Child, a posthuman being gazing at Earth.

The Mondoshawans belong to this lineage of benevolent stewards—a benevolence that, as Chapter II argued, is also the self-image of colonial custodianship—and *The Fifth Element* shares Clarke's premise that humanity is protected by beings it does not know. But it refuses Clarke's conclusion. Its ending is not posthuman. The human remains human, the god remains a god, and what saves the world is the relation between them, not the dissolution of one into the other.

Stanisław Lem's *Solaris* (1961) is the most rigorous fiction of failed contact. Its ocean, an intelligence beyond comprehension, produces "visitors" fashioned from the memories of the scientists who study it; Kelvin's visitor is his dead wife, Harey. Reconstructed, she learns what she is and, to spare Kelvin, consents to her own annihilation. Lem's scientist Snaut observes that human beings do not seek other worlds but mirrors. Andrei Tarkovsky's adaptation (1972) turned Lem's epistemological novel into a meditation on love and conscience, in which the reconstructed beloved becomes more human than her model. Harey and Leeloo are both manufactured beings whose fates turn on love. In *Solaris* love ends in the made being's self-erasure. In *The Fifth Element* love ends the made being's despair and completes her.

VIII.2 The Engineered Messiah: Herbert's *Dune*

Frank Herbert's *Dune* (1965) imagines a messiah produced by design. The Bene Gesserit sisterhood has bred human bloodlines for generations to produce the Kwisatz Haderach, a male who can access ancestral memory and see the future. Paul Atreides becomes that being, and his prescience —total knowledge of possible futures—traps him: he foresees the galactic jihad that will be waged in his name and cannot prevent it. Herbert intended the novel as a warning against charismatic saviours.

Leeloo is also an engineered messiah, regenerated from a genome whose "memory" exceeds the human, and the genealogical link is concrete: Jodorowsky's abortive *Dune* gathered the artists whose dispersal shaped the visual world from which Besson drew (Chapter III). The difference is

decisive. Paul's total knowledge issues in empire; Leeloo's total knowledge issues in despair; and she escapes Herbert's trap because her efficacy does not come from what she knows. It comes from a relation she cannot supply for herself.

The French Matrix: *Barbarella* VIII.3

Jean-Claude Forest's *Barbarella*, serialised from 1962 and filmed by Roger Vadim in 1968 with costumes to which Paco Rabanne contributed, is the most direct French ancestor of *The Fifth Element*'s cosmic eros, and its structural parallels are startling. Vadim's heroine is sent to find the scientist Durand Durand and arrives at the city of Sogo, built over the Mathmos, a living lake of liquid energy nourished by the evil of the city's inhabitants. When the Mathmos is unleashed it engulfs the city, but Barbarella is spared: her goodness is indigestible to it. Earlier, the blind angel Pygar, who has lost the will to fly, recovers it after making love with her; and the "Excessive Machine," designed to kill her by pleasure, is overwhelmed by her capacity for it.

Three homologies follow. Both films imagine an evil that feeds on evil: the Mathmos on the city's malice, the Great Evil on the military's fire. Both imagine a goodness that evil cannot assimilate. And both imagine love restoring a divine being's capacity to act. In *Barbarella* the woman restores the male angel's flight; in *The Fifth Element* the man restores the female god's light. Between them stands the couture lineage from Rabanne to Gaultier, and a shared conviction, very French and very unfashionable among serious critics, that erotic innocence can be a cosmological force.

Empathy and Information: Philip K. Dick VIII.4

Philip K. Dick's *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* (1968) makes empathy the criterion of humanity. Its society practises Mercerism: grasping the handles of an "empathy box," users fuse with the suffering of Wilbur Mercer, who climbs a hill under a hail of stones, and with one another. The Voigt-Kampff test distinguishes humans from androids by measuring empathic response. Leeloo, the manufactured being, is the most empathic creature in her film; her collapse before the archive is the empathy box applied to the whole of human history. Ridley Scott's *Blade Runner* (1982)

supplied the counterpart: Roy Batty, the replicant who has seen things humans would not believe, spares the man sent to kill him. In both Dick and Besson the made being proves its claim to personhood by suffering with others.

Dick's later *VALIS* (1981) imagines salvation as information: a living, divine information, the "plasmate," enters a human mind and liberates it from the prison of a world in which, as Dick put it, the Empire never ended. *VALIS* is a Gnostic novel; its saviour is knowledge. *The Fifth Element* is anti-*VALIS*. Its divine being is made of information and is wounded by information, and what saves is not a further transmission but an address.

VIII.5 The Integration of the Shadow: Le Guin, Lewis, Tolkien

Ursula K. Le Guin's *A Wizard of Earthsea* (1968) offers the closest literary analogue to the film's refusal to annihilate its Evil. The young wizard Ged, through pride, unleashes a shadow-creature into the world; he flees it, then hunts it to the edge of the sea, and finally names it with his own name, whereupon the two become one and Ged is made whole. The shadow is not destroyed but integrated. Le Guin's Earthsea is governed by the Equilibrium, a Taoist balance that every act of magic disturbs, and by the Old Speech, the Language of the Making, in which true names have power. The film's Divine Language and its dead moon in the sky belong to the same imaginative family: speech that touches the essence of things, and evil placed rather than erased.

C. S. Lewis's *Perelandra* (1943) offers the contrast. On an unfallen Venus, the Green Lady is tempted toward a new Fall by the Un-man, the scientist Weston possessed by an evil spirit, whose arguments are tireless. Ransom, unable to out-argue the tempter, kills him with his hands. The Fall is averted by combat. In *The Fifth Element* the unfallen divine woman is wounded not by a devil's sophistry but by the truth of the archive, and the man answers not with force but with love. Lewis's human protects innocence by violence; Besson's human heals wounded innocence by relation.

J. R. R. Tolkien's *Ainulindalë*, published in *The Silmarillion* (1977), imagines creation as a music sung by angelic powers, into which Melkor introduces discord; the creator Ilúvatar weaves the discord into a greater theme, so that even rebellion serves the glory of the whole. The Diva's aria,

which absorbs an alien electronic pulse, is an Ainulindalë in miniature, and the film's own discords of tone are woven into a single theme. But Tolkien's answer to evil remains a theodicy, an argument that discord will serve a greater harmony. The film's answer, as Chapter IX argues, is not an argument.

William Blake's prophetic books offer the most elaborate English precedent for a fourfold cosmos healed by love. In *The Four Zoas* (begun c. 1797) the primordial man Albion is divided into four warring faculties, Urizen, Luvah, Tharmas, and Urthona, whose strife is the fallen world; their reintegration is the apocalypse, and it comes through the mutual forgiveness that *Jerusalem* (1804–1820) makes the law of the restored cosmos. *The Marriage of Heaven and Hell* (c. 1790–1793) had insisted that "Without Contraries is no progression," and Blake's letter to Thomas Butts of 22 November 1802 prayed to be kept "From Single vision & Newton's sleep." Zorg is single vision in Blake's sense, a mind that reduces everything to one measure. The film's climax is fourfold vision restored: four held together by what passes between persons.

Love as Trigger: *The Matrix*, *Contact*, and the Willis Antithesis VIII.6

The structural twin of *The Fifth Element*'s climax appeared two years later. In Lana and Lilly Wachowski's *The Matrix* (1999), Neo, the One, is killed inside the simulation. Trinity tells his body that the Oracle told her she would fall in love with the One, and that therefore he cannot be dead; she kisses him; he revives and becomes the One in full. The messiah's power is activated by a human declaration of love. The genders are reversed —a woman declares to a male saviour—and that reversal is evidence that the structure is not intrinsically patriarchal. Two of the most influential science-fiction films of the late 1990s thus locate the messianic trigger outside the messiah, in another's love: a turn from sovereign to relational soteriology at the end of the millennium.

Robert Zemeckis's *Contact* (1997), adapted from Carl Sagan's novel (1985), stages a first contact in which the alien intelligence appears to the scientist Ellie Arroway in the form of her dead father. The cosmos speaks in the form of a beloved, and the experience cannot be verified by the instruments that made it possible. *Contact* shares with *The Fifth Element*

the conviction that what is decisive in a cosmic encounter is relational and therefore unarchivable.

The antithesis is supplied by the film's own star. In Michael Bay's *Armageddon* (1998), Bruce Willis's Harry Stamper saves the Earth from an asteroid by staying behind to detonate a nuclear device and dying. The American disaster cycle of those years—*Independence Day* (1996), with its computer virus and its kamikaze pilot; *Deep Impact* (1998), with its sacrificial astronauts; *Armageddon*—overwhelmingly imagined salvation as force consummated in sacrifice. Paul Verhoeven's *Starship Troopers* (1997) satirised the militarism of that imagination. One year before *Armageddon*, the same actor saved the Earth from a planetoid by declaring love. The comparison isolates the film's difference with the clarity of a controlled experiment: the same star, the same threat, the opposite soteriology. Sacrifice is not abolished in *The Fifth Element*—it is displaced onto the Diva—but it does not save.

VIII.7 Mythological Constellations: Eros before the Gods

Hesiod's *Theogony* (116–122) places Eros among the first powers: first came Chaos, then Earth, Tartarus, and Eros, fairest of the immortals, the limb-loosener who overpowers the mind and counsel of gods and men. Eros is older than the Olympians; love is cosmogonic before it is personal. The Orphic theogonies made the point luminous. In the Orphic tradition the first-born god, Protogonos, hatches from a cosmic egg, golden-winged and double-sexed, and is called Phanes, "the one who brings to light," and Eros. Aristophanes parodies the same myth in the *Birds* (693–702): black-winged Night lays a wind-egg in Erebus, and from it springs golden-winged Eros. Leeloo's emergence from the regeneration chamber, and her final radiance, are Phanetic: a first-born of light who is also love—with the difference that her light appears only when she is loved.

The Vedic Hymn of Creation (*Ṛgveda* 10.129) says that in the beginning desire (*kāma*) came upon the One, the first seed of mind, and that the sages, searching in their hearts, found the bond (*bandhu*) of being in non-being. Cosmogonic desire is a *bond*. The hymn ends with a celebrated doubt: the one who oversees creation in the highest heaven surely knows—or perhaps does not know. The film preserves something of that doubt. No

one in the temple, the Supreme Being included, knows in advance whether love will suffice.

Three further figures complete the constellation. The Dioscuri, Castor the mortal and Polydeuces the immortal, are joined by a love that leads the immortal to share his immortality with his dead brother, so that the twins alternate between Olympus and the underworld (Pindar, *Nemean* 10). The contest that dispatches Korben and Leeloo as a couple is sponsored by a brand called Gemini: the mortal and the immortal sent as twins. From the union of Ares and Aphrodite, Hesiod reports (*Theogony* 933–937), Harmonia was born, and Empedocles used Harmonia as a name for Love; Renaissance Neoplatonism read Botticelli's *Venus and Mars* (c. 1485) as Love disarming Strife (Wind 1958). Korben the soldier and Leeloo the god are Mars and Venus, and the cosmos they restore is Harmonia. Finally, Buddhist eschatology awaits Maitreya, the future Buddha whose name derives from *maitrī*, loving-kindness, and who will appear when the teaching has been forgotten. The saviour of the last age is named Love.

Two myths sharpen the film's difference from Gnosticism. Irenaeus (*Adversus haereses* I.23) reports that Simon Magus taught that the First Thought (*Ennoia*) of the Father had descended into the world, been imprisoned by hostile angels in successive female bodies, and been found by Simon in a brothel in Tyre. The fallen divine feminine is redeemed by a man who recognises her. Leeloo falls into a taxi and is recognised by its driver. But the Gnostic redeemer liberates by knowledge, and Korben by love. Joseph Campbell's *The Hero with a Thousand Faces* (1949), which Christopher Vogler's 1985 studio memorandum and his book *The Writer's Journey* (1992) turned into Hollywood doctrine, names a stage "The Meeting with the Goddess" and describes it as the mystical marriage of the hero with the Queen Goddess of the World. The film follows Campbell through the refusal of the call and the meeting with the goddess and then bends him: the hero does not undergo apotheosis, and the ultimate boon is not won but given.

Philosophical Constellations: Relation First VIII.8

Martin Buber's *Ich und Du* (1923) begins from a sentence the film could take as its motto: *Im Anfang ist die Beziehung*—in the beginning is the

relation. Buber distinguished the basic word I–It, the attitude of use and experience toward objects, from the basic word I–Thou, spoken with the whole being to a presence that cannot be possessed. Zorg's world of equipment, the state's world of assets, and the media's world of audiences are It-worlds. And Buber taught that every particular Thou is a glimpse through to the eternal Thou. Korben's declaration is that teaching made literal: an I–Thou addressed to a particular person who is also the divine.

Alfred North Whitehead's *Process and Reality* (1929) closes by describing God in his consequent nature as "the great companion—the fellow-sufferer who understands," a God affected by the world rather than impassive toward it; Charles Hartshorne's process theology developed the conception of a God whose experience grows with the world's. Leeloo, who is wounded by the history she reads, is a process deity. Simone Weil's *La Pesanteur et la grâce* (1947) gives the interval its most concentrated formula in the chapter titled "Metaxu": every separation is a link (*toute séparation est un lien*). Weil's image is of two prisoners in adjoining cells who communicate by tapping on the wall that divides them; the wall separates them and is also their means of speech.

Søren Kierkegaard's *Works of Love* (1847) insists on the duty to love the people we see, the actual persons before us rather than an ideal. Leeloo's crisis is love of humanity in abstraction, conducted through an archive; Korben's answer is love of the one person he sees. But Kierkegaard subordinated preferential, erotic love to love of the neighbour, and Anders Nygren's *Agape and Eros* (1930–1936) hardened the opposition into a dichotomy between God's unmotivated self-giving and acquisitive human desire. The film refuses the dichotomy. Its erotic declaration functions as agape: gratuitous, unmotivated by the beloved's merit, salvific. Benedict XVI's encyclical *Deus caritas est* (2005), which argued that eros and agape are not opposed but must be united, states theologically what the film staged eight years earlier.

Finally, the late twentieth century witnessed a relational turn in physics and metaphysics. Carlo Rovelli's "Relational Quantum Mechanics" (1996), published the year before the film, proposed that the state of a physical system is defined only relative to another system. Karen Barad's agential realism (2007) argued that relata do not precede their relations but emerge through them. No influence is claimed. But the film's substitution

of relation for substance belongs to an intellectual weather in which the oldest metaphysical hierarchy—things first, relations second—was being inverted from several directions at once.

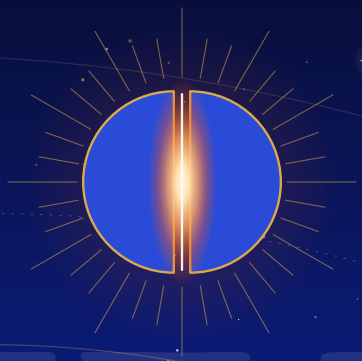
Synthesis: Four Soteriologies VIII.9

The comparison yields four soteriologies. The *evolutionary* (Clarke, Kubrick) saves by transcending the human. The *gnostic* (Dick's *VALIS*, Jodorowsky, the prescience of Herbert's messiah) saves by knowledge. The *sacrificial-forceful* (Lewis, the American disaster cycle) saves by combat and death. The *relational* (Forest and Vadim, the Wachowskis, Besson and Kamen) saves by a bond. *The Fifth Element* does not merely belong to the fourth type. It is the work in which the fourth type is most explicitly set against the other three: its Mondoshawans embody the evolutionary stewards, its archive the gnostic option, its generals and its Diva the sacrificial-forceful, and its climax rejects them all for the interval between two persons. Chapter IX gives that interval its theory.

VIII.9

Synthesis: Four Soteriologies

Year	Work	What saves (or fails to)	Place of love	Relation to The Fifth Element
1943	C. S. Lewis, *Perelandra*	A man's combat against the tempter	*Protective, not activating*	Force guards innocence; the film heals wounded innocence
1953	Arthur C. Clarke, *Childhood's End*	Evolutionary absorption into the Overmind	*An attachment to be severed*	Benevolent stewards; posthuman ending refused
1961; 1972	Stanisław Lem, *Solaris*; Tarkovsky's film	Nothing: contact fails	*The made beloved annihilates herself*	Tragic inverse of the manufactured beloved
1965	Frank Herbert, *Dune*	An engineered messiah's prescience	*Subordinate to destiny*	Engineered messiah undone by knowing too much
1962; 1968	*Barbarella* (Forest; Vadim)	Goodness the Mathmos cannot absorb	*Restores the angel's flight*	French matrix, genders reversed
1968	Philip K. Dick, *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?*	Empathy as the mark of the human	*Empathic fusion*	Leeloo's hyper-empathy
1968	Ursula K. Le Guin, *A Wizard of Earthsea*	Naming and integrating the shadow	*Self-acceptance*	Evil integrated, not annihilated
1968	Kubrick and Clarke, *2001: A Space Odyssey*	Evolutionary leap via the monolith	*Absent*	Transcendence without relation
1980–1988	Jodorowsky and Mœbius, *L'Incal*	Gnosis and cosmic recapitulation	*Present but subordinate*	Closest rival; diverges at the decisive point
1998	Michael Bay, *Armageddon*	Nuclear self-sacrifice	*Familial motive*	Same star, opposite soteriology
1999	The Wachowskis, *The Matrix*	A declaration of love revives the One	*Activating*	Structural twin, genders reversed



Chapter IX

The Quintessence of the Between

Toward an Osculatory Theodicy

Erlösung dem Erlöser!

— Richard Wagner, *Parsifal* (1882), final words

The preceding chapters assembled a constellation. This chapter draws the figure. It defines **metaxic quintessentialism** as the doctrine that the principle which binds, completes, and activates the elements of a cosmos is not a further element but an interval (*metaxu*) constituted by love; that this interval is efficacious only when enacted between persons; and that the divine itself, in such a cosmos, acts through the interval and never around it. The doctrine is articulated in four propositions—the pemptic inversion, the theurgic inversion, the osculatory theodicy, and the sociocosmic tetrasomia—and two corollaries. A final section states and answers the principal objections.

The Pemptic Inversion: From Substance to Interval IX.1

Diotima's speech in the *Symposium* contains the most exact ancient statement of the film's two problems and of their single solution. Eros, she tells Socrates, is not a god but a great *daimōn*, and everything daimonic is *between* (*metaxu*) god and mortal (202e). Its office is to interpret and

convey human things to the gods and divine things to human beings; being in the middle, it fills up the interval, *so that the whole is bound together with itself* (*hōste to pan auto hautōi sundedesthai*). And she adds the principle that makes the intermediary necessary: god does not mingle with man (*theos de anthrōpōi ou meignutai*, 203a); all converse between gods and mortals passes through the daimonic.

The film's two problems are Diotima's. The first is cosmological: four stones, inert in isolation, must be bound into a whole that acts. The second is theological: a god who has descended into the world cannot act upon it directly, because the world has persuaded her that it is not worth her action. Diotima's Eros solves both at once. It binds the all to itself, and it carries what is divine to what is human. The film's climax is the *Symposium*'s definition performed.

This is the pemptic inversion (from Greek *pemptos*, "fifth"): the fifth is not a fifth thing but the betweenness of things. Gilbert Ryle's category mistake, posed in the Introduction, is thereby resolved. The fifth element is not one more element alongside the four, as the University is not one more college; it is the way the four, and the human and the divine, are bound. The lineage that runs from Empedocles' Love "among" the roots, through Plato's most beautiful bond, the Stoic tension of sympathy, the world-spirit of Ficino and Agrippa, and Nāgārjuna's identification of emptiness with dependent origination, to Weil's *metaxu* and Buber's relation that is in the beginning, culminates in a film that makes the interval its protagonist.

The inversion is not, however, a modern relativism set against the Western tradition. It recovers that tradition's summit. Augustine's *De Trinitate* (Book XV) came to understand the Holy Spirit as the mutual love of the Father and the Son; Bernard of Clairvaux (*Sermones super Cantica* 8) called the Spirit the kiss of Father and Son, their unbreakable bond and undivided love; and Thomas Aquinas (*Summa theologiae* I, q. 29, a. 4) concluded that a divine person signifies *relatio ut subsistens*—a relation as subsisting. In the doctrine of the Trinity, Latin theology reached the most exalted precedent in Western thought for the claim that a relation can be as real as a substance, indeed more real, since the divine persons are nothing other than subsistent relations. Metaxic quintessentialism transposes that doctrine from the inner life of God to the cosmos: the fifth is a subsistent relation.

Luce Irigaray's reading of Diotima in *Éthique de la différence sexuelle* (1984), "L'amour sorcier," supplies the doctrine's caution. Irigaray praised Diotima for refusing to collapse love into either of its poles and faulted the later turn in her speech, in which love becomes a means—to procreation, to ascent—and loses its status as the intermediary in its own right. The interval, Irigaray insisted, must be preserved, not consumed. The film obeys the caution. Korben does not become divine and Leeloo does not become merely human; the light issues from between them, and they remain two.

Structural anthropology supplies the interval with a human bearer. In "The Structural Study of Myth" (1955) Lévi-Strauss argued that mythic thought proceeds from the awareness of an opposition toward its progressive mediation, and that trickster figures such as Raven and Coyote serve as mediators because, as eaters of carrion, they stand between hunter and hunted, life and death. Korben, whose name sounds the Old French *corbin*, "raven," occupies exactly that position: a soldier who has stopped killing, a driver who carries others between levels, a mortal who stands between a god and a species. He is not the fifth element. He is the point at which the interval takes a human face.

The precise formula is therefore grammatical. The film calls Leeloo the fifth element, and in the substantial register she is. But the plot shows that she is the fifth element only as a term of a relation, as the Father is God in Trinitarian theology not apart from the Son and the Spirit. The fifth element is not a noun but a preposition. Its name is *between*.

The Theurgic Inversion: The God Who Must Be Loved IX.2

Chapter I recorded the grammatical shift on which this proposition rests. Aristotle's unmoved mover moves the heavens as being loved (*kinei hōs erōmenon*); the film's Supreme Being is moved by being loved (*kineitai*). The God of the philosophers is the object of all love and the subject of none; the god of the film can act only when she is the object of one human love.

The late Neoplatonist Iamblichus, defending the Egyptian priestly tradition against Porphyry in *De mysteriis* (II.11), argued that it is not thought (*theoria*) that unites the soul with the gods but the performance of ineffable acts (*theourgia*, "god-work"). The opposition maps exactly onto the film's crisis. Leeloo possesses total *theoria*—she has read everything—

and it unites her with nothing; what unites the divine and the human in the temple is an act. That the film's theurgy is performed in an Egyptian temple, the setting Iamblichus defended, is a further coincidence the method of this dissertation allows itself to note.

The Jewish mystical tradition gives the theurgic inversion its most developed form. Moshe Idel (1988) identified at the heart of Kabbalah a "theosophical-theurgical" current in which human performance of the commandments affects the inner life of God. The *Zohar* formulates the principle that an arousal from below (*it'aruta di-letata*) awakens an arousal from above (*it'aruta di-le'ela*). And the Lurianic Kabbalah of sixteenth-century Safed, reconstructed by Gershom Scholem (1941), supplies a myth whose stages map onto the film's plot with remarkable fidelity.

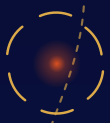
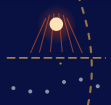
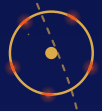
In Lurianic practice, the performance of a commandment was prefaced by a declaration of intent: *le-shem yiḥud kudsha brikh hu u-shekhinteh*—for the sake of the unification of the Holy One, blessed be He, and His Shekhinah. The human act is performed in order that God may be united with God's own exiled presence. Korben's declaration is an act of exactly this kind. It does not ask the divine for anything. It supplies the divine with the condition of its own integrity.

The post-Holocaust theology examined in Chapter VI states the same inversion without myth. Hans Jonas's God, having renounced omnipotence in creating, depends on human beings; Etty Hillesum resolves to help God help us. Meister Eckhart had already sounded the reciprocity in a sermon on Ecclesiasticus 24: the eye with which I see God is the same eye with which God sees me. Orthodox Christianity names it *synergeia*, the co-operation of divine and human will, warranted by Paul's description of the apostles as God's fellow-workers (*synergoi*, 1 Corinthians 3:9).

The theurgic inversion entails a further concept, here called **counter-kenosis**. In the hymn of Philippians 2:7 Christ "emptied himself" (*heauton ekenōsen*), taking the form of a servant. Leeloo's career is a kenosis: descent, fall, nakedness, statelessness, wounding, and finally the grief of the archive, which empties her of the will to act. The film's insight is that divine self-emptying is not, in this cosmos, self-completing. It requires a reciprocal self-emptying of the human toward the divine: an exposure without guarantee. Jean-Luc Marion's *Le Phénomène érotique* (2003) describes the moment at which the lover ceases to ask whether anyone loves him and asks

IX.2

The Theurgic Inversion

		Lurianic stage	Meaning	Correlate in the film
1		Tzimtzum	The divine contracts and withdraws to make room for the world	*The Mondoshawans withdraw from Earth in 1914*
2		Shevirat ha-kelim	The vessels shatter, unable to hold the divine light	*The Mondoshawan ship is destroyed; Zorg's glass; Leeloo's containment cell*
3		Nitzotzot	Sparks of light fall and are trapped in the husks of matter	*A single living cell survives in a gloved hand*
4		Birur	The sparks are sifted out and gathered	*The laboratory regenerates the body from the cell*
5		Galut ha-Shekhinah	The feminine presence of God wanders in exile	*Leeloo, stateless and wounded in a hostile city*
6		Tikkun	Repair of the world through human acts	*Breath, sweat, sand, and a last match offered in the temple*
7		Yiḥud	Unification of the Holy One and the Shekhinah	*The embrace from which the light issues*

instead whether he can love first—the lover's advance (*l'avance*). Leeloo has just said that she does not know love. Korben loves first, without knowing whether she can answer. That advance is counter-kenosis: the human emptying that completes the divine one.

Wagner's *Parsifal* names the whole structure in its final words. The Grail community's redeemer—Christ, whose blood the Grail holds—is himself in need of redemption, wounded in the wound of the king who guards him, and the redemption is achieved by a simple man made wise through compassion (*durch Mitleid wissend, der reine Tor*). Redemption to the Redeemer. Nietzsche mocked the formula in *Der Fall Wagner* (1888), but it states with precision what *The Fifth Element* stages: the saviour must be saved, and the saving is done by a fool who knows nothing except how to love.

Goethe's *Faust* ends with a mystic chorus declaring that the Eternal-Feminine draws us upward (*Das Ewig-Weibliche / Zieht uns hinan*). The film reverses the direction of that pull. Its feminine divine does not draw the human upward; she must herself be drawn back toward the world by a human love. The reversal is the theurgic inversion stated in Goethe's terms, and it is also counter-kenosis: the redeemer descends, and must be met.

IX.3 The Osculatory Theodicy: The Kiss as the Answer to Evil

Chapter VI left the film's problem in its sharpest form. The archive constitutes an indictment of humanity; Leeloo, having read it, asks why life should be saved; and no further information can answer her, because information is what condemned. In the temple Korben first tries argument: there are good things too, worth saving. The argument fails, as it must; the archive holds more evidence than he does. He stops arguing. He tells her that he loves her, and he kisses her.

The osculatory theodicy is the doctrine that this sequence is not a sentimental evasion of the problem of evil but its only adequate answer. It has four moments.

First, the indictment is conceded. Kant's essay "Über das Misslingen aller philosophischen Versuche in der Theodicee" (1791) concluded that every philosophical theodicy fails and that only what he called authentic theodicy survives—the sincerity of Job, who refuses the arguments of his friends.

The film is Kantian in this respect. It does not dispute the archive. War happened; the footage is true. No answer that denies the evidence is offered.

Second, argument is declined. Dostoevsky understood that Ivan Karamazov's rebellion cannot be refuted on its own terms. In "The Grand Inquisitor" (*The Brothers Karamazov*, Book V, chapter 5), the Prisoner listens in silence to the Inquisitor's immense argument that humanity cannot bear freedom, and at its end answers by kissing the old man on his bloodless lips. Alyosha then kisses Ivan, who cries out in delight that it is literary theft. Dostoevsky intended the teaching of the elder Zosima on active love, in Book VI, as the novel's reply to Ivan; the kiss is that reply's seal. This dissertation calls it the **Karamazov kiss**: the non-argumentative answer to theodicy, which does not refute the indictment but changes the relation in which it is uttered. Korben's kiss is a Karamazov kiss.

Third, love confers value rather than finding it. Leeloo's question is an anthropodicy: is humanity worthy of being saved? Any answer that tries to prove humanity's worth must lose against the archive. Martin Luther's twenty-eighth thesis at Heidelberg (1518) distinguished two loves: *Amor Dei non invenit sed creat suum diligibile*—the love of God does not find but creates what is lovable to it—whereas human love comes into being through what pleases it. Harry Frankfurt's *The Reasons of Love* (2004) argued, in a secular idiom, that we do not love things because we recognise their value; rather, what we love acquires value for us because we love it. Korben's declaration answers the anthropodicy by changing its logic. He does not prove that humanity deserves saving. He loves one of its witnesses, and his love—human love functioning in Luther's divine mode—creates the lovability the archive could not find. The human loves as God loves so that God can love the human again. The osculatory theodicy and the theurgic inversion are one movement seen from two sides.

Fourth, the kiss is mediation embodied. The Song of Songs opens with a petition—"Let him kiss me with the kisses of his mouth" (1:2)—on which Bernard of Clairvaux built, in his second sermon on the Canticle, a Christology of the kiss. The mouth that kisses, Bernard taught, is the Word assuming flesh; the one kissed is the human nature assumed; and the kiss itself, formed from both, is the Mediator between God and humanity, the man Christ Jesus. The kiss *is* the between. In the eighth sermon Bernard went further and identified the Holy Spirit with the kiss shared by Father

and Son. The film's kiss, exchanged by a god and a man at the centre of four stones, is Bernard's Mediator enacted: the interval made flesh, and the flesh made interval.

The temple confirms the identification. Exodus 25:22 locates the divine speech in the Holy of Holies "from between the two cherubims" upon the ark. The Babylonian Talmud (*Yoma* 54a) preserves the tradition that when Israel went up for the pilgrimage festivals, the curtain was drawn back to show the cherubim intertwined with one another, and the people were told that their love before God was like the love of male and female. The divine presence speaks from the interval of an embrace. The final tableau of *The Fifth Element*—an inner sanctum, two figures embracing, light issuing from the space between them—is structurally a Holy of Holies. And the Song of Songs supplies the light's name. Love is strong as death, it says (8:6), and its flashes are flashes of fire, *shalhevetyah*: a word that ends in *Yah*, the divine name, and has been read as "a flame of the Lord"—perhaps the only place in that book where God is named, and named inside love's fire.

The speech-act theory of the twentieth century explains why a sentence can do what argument cannot. J. L. Austin's *How to Do Things with Words* (1962) distinguished utterances that describe from utterances that perform. "I love you" is not a report on an inner state; it is a commitment that alters the relation in which it is spoken. Roland Barthes (1977) described *je-t'-aime* as a holophrase without usage or elsewhere, closer to a cry than a proposition. Alain Badiou's *Éloge de l'amour* (2009) made the declaration the moment at which the chance of an encounter is fixed into the beginning of a truth, the construction of a world from the point of view of the Two. Each account converges on the film's logic. The archive is constative: a vast description. The answer is performative: a sentence that brings into being what it names.

The osculatory theodicy may now be defined. It is a response to the problem of evil that concedes the indictment, declines argument, confers value by love, and enacts the mediation of the divine and the human in an embodied gesture. It is neither a justification of God before humanity nor of humanity before God. It is the event in which the two cease to stand before each other as judge and accused and stand instead with each other, as lovers.

The Sociocosmic Tetrasomia and the Political Theology of the Couple IX.4

Chapter VII showed that the four elements are held by four institutions—earth by the state, fire by the armaments economy, air by the media, water by art—and that none of them can administer the fifth. Love cannot be decreed by the state, manufactured by industry, broadcast by the media, or performed by art, though art comes nearest and dies. The political consequence is stated with unusual clarity by two German jurists.

Alain Badiou's *L'Être et l'événement* (1988) named four conditions of philosophy, the four procedures through which truths are produced: science, politics, art, and love. The film stages all four. Science is the laboratory, politics the state, art the Diva, love the couple. It also ranks them. The laboratory produces a god it cannot keep; the state's politics is reduced to force and waiting; art knows the answer and is killed for carrying it; only love completes its procedure in the temple. Badiou would not accept the ranking, since his four conditions are coequal. The film's wager is that, at the end of a world, the procedure that cannot be delegated is the one that decides.

Carl Schmitt's *Politische Theologie* (1922) opens with a definition: *Souverän ist, wer über den Ausnahmezustand entscheidet*—sovereign is he who decides on the exception. *The Fifth Element* stages the exception par excellence, an emergency in which the survival of the planet is at stake. The decision on which everything depends is not made by the President, who waits by a screen, but by two private persons in a temple. In the film's state of exception, sovereignty migrates to the couple. Schmitt's doctrine is inverted: the sovereign in the exception is the lover.

The inversion is moral as well as formal. Schmitt joined the National Socialist party in May 1933, and in August 1934 he published "Der Führer schützt das Recht," a defence of the killings of 30 June to 2 July 1934, in which the SS and the Gestapo, on Hitler's orders, murdered Ernst Röhm and other SA leaders together with political opponents—at least eighty-five people by historians' count. Schmitt presented those murders as an act of genuine justice by the leader in an emergency. The film's exception is decided by an act that kills no one.

Ernst-Wolfgang Böckenförde's celebrated dictum (1967) holds that the liberal, secularised state *lebt von Voraussetzungen, die er selbst nicht garantieren kann*—lives on presuppositions that it cannot itself guarantee. The Federated Territories survive on a presupposition they cannot produce: a love between two persons that no institution commands. The film is a parable of Böckenförde's dilemma written at cosmic scale. Its coda draws the moral: the President and his officials wait outside the door of the chamber in which the couple are together, unable to enter, unable even to deliver their congratulations. The polis waits upon the couple.

The proposition also corrects Hannah Arendt. In *The Human Condition* Arendt judged love worldless and therefore antipolitical—perhaps the most powerful of antipolitical forces—because it consumes the in-between that both relates and separates people in a shared world. The film proposes that, in extremity, love is not the destroyer of the in-between but its last form. When every institution of the shared world has failed, the world is saved from the one in-between that remains. *Amor mundi* is achieved through love of a single person.

IX.5 Corollary I: The Carnivalesque Sublime

The theology argued in this chapter could not survive a solemn film. A cosmos saved by a kiss, presented without irony from beginning to end, would be kitsch in Kundera's exact sense: a denial of the body's indignities and an invitation to weep at one's own capacity to be moved. The film's carnival, analysed in Chapter VII, is the theology's armour. Bakhtinian laughter disarms the cosmic terror that the sublime Evil provokes; the grotesque body—choking, sweating, smoking, screaming—keeps sincerity honest; and camp exhausts the spectator's irony before the climax arrives, so that the declaration of love can be heard without a defensive smile. The carnivalesque sublime is not a tonal accident. It is the formal condition under which an osculatory theodicy can be believed for the length of a scene. Laughter is sincerity's immune system.

Corollary II: Cosmogonic Non-Annihilation and the Renewal of Love IX.6

The Evil is not destroyed. Struck by the light, it cools into a dead planetoid and remains in Earth's sky, as Tiamat's body became the firmament (Chapter II), as the dragon's defeat leaves the moon under the feet of the woman clothed with the sun (Revelation 12:1), as Ged's shadow is named and taken into himself (Chapter VIII), as the shadow in Jung's psychology is integrated rather than extirpated. The film is, in Norman Cohn's terms, pre-Zoroastrian: it promises no final abolition of chaos. The Evil returns every five thousand years.

Boethius gave this cosmology its classical form in the eighth metre of Book II of the *Consolation*. That the world varies its seasons in stable concord, that warring seeds (*pugnantia semina*) keep a perpetual treaty (*foedus perpetuum*), that the sea keeps its bounds—all this, Boethius sings, is bound by Love, *hanc rerum seriem ligat … amor*, which rules earth and sea and commands the heavens. The elements are not reconciled once and for all; they are held in treaty by a love that must continually hold them. The poem ends with a petition addressed to humanity: *O felix hominum genus, / si vestros animos amor / quo caelum regitur regat*—O happy race of men, if the love by which heaven is ruled might rule your minds. That petition is the film's last word, spoken in Latin fifteen centuries before it.

The ethical consequence is that the quintessence is a practice, not a possession. No one can own the fifth element, because it exists only when enacted, and it must be enacted again in every age the Evil returns. Augustine's brief definition of virtue as *ordo amoris*, the order of love (*De civitate Dei* XV.22), Arendt's *amor mundi*, and even Nietzsche's *amor fati*—the love that wills the return of all things—converge on this point: what saves is a love that knows evil will come back and loves anyway.

The coda completes the figure. The chamber in which the Supreme Being was regenerated—the machine for making gods—is the room in which the lovers are found at the end. Bergson's machine becomes a bridal chamber. The alchemical opus ends where *Die Chymische Hochzeit Christiani Rosencreutz* (1616) and Jung's *Mysterium Coniunctionis* (1955–1956) said it must, in the *coniunctio*; Campbell's hero ends in the hieros gamos. The

last product of the technology that made a god is not a weapon but a relation.

Jung's reading of alchemy gives the coda one more figure. For Jung the quaternity becomes whole only through a centre: the mandala, four quarters around a midpoint, was his image of the Self, and he returned repeatedly to the alchemists' axiom of Maria—one becomes two, two becomes three, and out of the third comes the one as the fourth. The temple floor of the climax, four stones around a centre, is a mandala in Jung's sense; the coda moves its centre from a sanctum to a bedroom. The Self of this cosmos is not a solitary integration but a couple.

IX.7 Objections and Replies

Objection 1: the reading over-intellectualises a commercial entertainment. Reply: the dissertation claims no authorial intention for its hermeneutic register. Its warrant is Warburg's doctrine of the afterlife of forms and Lévi-Strauss's account of myths that think themselves in their tellers. A bricolage of pre-constrained elements carries meanings its assembler need not intend, and the analyst's task is to read what the elements carry.

Objection 2: the film's gender politics compromise its theology. Reply: the objection is partly conceded (Chapter VII.9). The film's realisation of the structure is asymmetrical: he speaks, she receives—and the man who speaks is the man who earlier kissed her while she was unconscious, an act the narrative never reckons with. But the structure itself is not gendered. *The Matrix* realises it with the roles reversed, and Irigaray's account of the interval shows how the divine can be located between the sexes rather than in either. Metaxic quintessentialism is a theory of the interval, not of male agency.

Objection 3: "love conquers all" is a sentimental cliche. Reply: the theory makes no such claim. Love does not conquer the Evil; it binds and places it, and the Evil returns. Love does not refute the archive; it concedes the archive and confers a value the archive cannot record. And the carnival protects the claim from kitsch.

Objection 4: the film's action violence contradicts its cosmic nonviolence. Reply: the tension is real and is conceded (Chapter V.7). The film's ethics are stratified: force may protect and delay at the human scale, but at the

cosmic scale, where the adversary is the sum of violence, only an act that exits the mimetic economy can avail.

Objection 5: the comparative method appropriates non-Western traditions. Reply: the comparisons are the analyst's and are labelled as such; the Indian, Japanese, Chinese, and Mexica materials are used to sharpen a theoretical problem, not to assert influence, under the discipline Jonathan Z. Smith prescribed. The film's own Egypt is acknowledged to be a European, Hermetic, and Orientalist construction (Said 1978; Hornung 1999).

Objection 6: the theurgic inversion is heterodox, making God dependent on creatures. Reply: it is heterodox with respect to classical theism and orthodox with respect to a substantial counter-tradition: Kabbalistic theurgy, Orthodox synergy, process theology, and the theology written after Auschwitz by Jonas and lived by Hillesum. The film belongs to that counter-tradition, and so does the century whose archive it makes its god read.

Objection 7: the osculatory theodicy is what Camus called philosophical suicide. Camus charged Kierkegaard, Chestov, and Jaspers with escaping the absurd by a leap into a transcendence that reason could not warrant, and a theodicy that answers the indictment with a kiss rather than an argument might seem to commit the same evasion. Reply: this is the strongest objection the dissertation faces, and it fails on one point. The leap Camus condemned appeals beyond the world, so that the absurd is redeemed elsewhere. Korben appeals to nothing beyond the world. He concedes the archive in full, offers no hidden harmony, and declares a love that exists only here, between two persons. Camus himself, in *L'Homme révolté* (1951), found in revolt a first value that is shared—*Je me révolte, donc nous sommes*, I rebel, therefore we exist—and the osculatory theodicy is closer to that "we" than to any leap. It answers the absurd not by escaping it but by refusing to face it alone.

The Thesis Stated IX.8

> The Fifth Element *is a cosmogram of the late twentieth century in which the classical question of the quintessence is answered by relation rather than substance. Its four elements are four institutions*

> *and four bodily gestures; its Evil is the cumulative form of violence, which force enlarges; its Supreme Being is a god who has read the archive of the century of total war and despaired of the species; and its salvation is a declaration and a kiss, which concede the indictment, decline argument, confer value, and embody the mediation of the divine and the human. The fifth element is not an element. It is the between, and the between is love—not as sentiment, but as the subsistent relation by which the cosmos is bound to itself and the divine is enabled to act. This is metaxic quintessentialism.*



Conclusion

Theses on the Quintessence

The argument of this dissertation can be condensed into twenty-two theses, after the manner in which Luther opened a reformation, Marx settled accounts with Feuerbach, and Benjamin took leave of the concept of history.

The title is a category mistake that the film exists to correct. The fifth element is not one more element alongside the four, as the University is not one more college; it is the way the four are bound. 1

The history of the quintessence divides into a substantial and a medial lineage. Aristotle's aether and the scholastic *quinta essentia* made the fifth a thing; Empedocles' Love "among" the roots, Plato's *desmos*, Stoic sympathy, the *spiritus mundi* of Ficino and Agrippa, and Nāgārjuna's emptiness made it a bond. The film's title belongs to the first lineage; its plot belongs to the second. 2

Every substance in the film fails. Stone, body, genome, weapon, state, market, medium, and art each prove insufficient; efficacy is conferred only on a relation. 3

The film's cosmos is a cosmogram of the chaos-combat. Its temple is an anti-Apophis machine that maintains *ma'at* as connective justice; its 4

Evil returns periodically; its saviour is regenerated from preserved germinal matter; its decisive fire is a New Fire kindled at the brink.

5 **The film's theology is French before it is universal.** Its Supreme Being is the *Être suprême* of 1794 corrected: where Robespierre joined virtue to terror, the film joins being to love.

6 **The laboratory that makes the god is a literalised Bergsonian machine, and it cannot keep what it makes.** Technology can produce a god; the god's first act is to refuse to be standing-reserve.

7 **The first divine word that human beings understand is a law of consent.** Korben's first kiss, on an unconscious woman, is a non-consensual act that the film plays partly as comedy and never reckons with. Its arc runs from that assault to a final kiss that Leeloo returns, but it shows reciprocation rather than the permission she demanded, so the hero's redemption is asserted rather than earned.

8 **Zorg's theodicy of breakage is refuted twice.** Bastiat's "unseen" shows that destruction is loss; the cherry shows that care, which produces nothing, is what saves.

9 **The Evil is mimetic violence rendered as a celestial body.** Whatever force is thrown at it becomes it; only an act that exits the mimetic economy can avail.

10 **The archive is structurally biased toward catastrophe.** War is documentable and love is not; a god who learns humanity from its archive will learn to despair of it, unless she reads it as a record of named perpetrators, victims, and rescuers rather than as the indictment of one agent called humanity.

11 **Leeloo's despair is the Fall of God.** The deity, not the creature, eats of the tree of the knowledge of good and evil, and her fall merits a human redeemer.

12 **Her question is an anthropodicy, and no argument can answer it.** Korben's brief attempt to argue fails because the archive holds more evidence than he does.

The answer is a declaration that confers value rather than finding it. 13
The human loves in Luther's divine mode—creating, not discovering, what is lovable—so that God can love the human again.

The kiss is the Mediator. With Bernard, it is the between made flesh; 14
with Dostoevsky, it is the non-argumentative answer to theodicy; with the Talmud, it is the embrace from whose interval the divine presence speaks.

The divine in this cosmos is moved by being loved. Aristotle's *kinei* 15
becomes *kineitai*; the arousal from below awakens the arousal from above; the saviour must be saved.

Divine kenosis requires human counter-kenosis. The god's self-empty- 16
ing is completed only by the human's exposure in a love that risks being unreturned—the lover's advance.

The four elements are the four institutions of late modernity. Earth is 17
the state, fire the armaments economy, air the media, water art; none can administer the fifth, and art, which comes nearest, dies.

The broadcast ether is a counterfeit quintessence. It connects everyone 18
and relates no one; the true medium carries one sentence to one person.

In the state of exception, sovereignty migrates to the couple. Schmitt is 19
inverted and Böckenförde confirmed: the polis lives on a presupposition it cannot produce, and in the coda it waits outside the lovers' door.

The carnival is the theology's armour. Laughter disarms cosmic terror, 20
the grotesque body keeps sincerity from kitsch, and camp exhausts irony before the declaration is spoken.

Evil is placed, not annihilated; therefore love must be renewed. The 21
dead moon is Tiamat's body set in the sky; the Evil will return; the quintessence is a practice, not a possession.

The fifth element is not an element. It is the between. The 22
Mondoshawan's dictum is the film's last word as well as its first: time does not matter; life does—and life, in this cosmos, is what passes between.

Dante ended the *Commedia* with the love that moves the sun and the other stars. Besson and Kamen's film ends with a love that stills a dark star. The difference measures the distance between a medieval cosmos, in which love was the first mover of a universe already ordered, and a late-modern one,

in which love must intervene, in the last seconds, in a universe that its own institutions have brought to the brink. The two endings nevertheless share their premise: that love is not a sentiment within the cosmos but the bond of the cosmos, the interval by which the whole is held together with itself.

The dissertation's contribution is threefold. To film studies, it offers a reading of a canonical popular film as a work of systematic cosmological and theological thought, and a model for reading the *cinéma du look* as a carrier of archaic and esoteric structures rather than an aesthetics of surface alone. To the history of ideas, it recovers the medial lineage of the quintessence—from Empedocles through Ficino and Agrippa to Weil and Buber—as a counter-tradition to the substantial aether, and traces that lineage's afterlife in mass culture. To philosophical theology, it proposes metaxic quintessentialism and its four propositions—the pemptic inversion, the theurgic inversion, the osculatory theodicy, and the sociocosmic tetrasomia—as a coherent response to the problem of evil after the twentieth century: a position that concedes the archive's indictment and answers it not with an argument but with a relation.

Three lines of further research follow. The first is auteurist: Besson's *Lucy* (2014) offers a controlled counter-example—apotheosis through total information without relation—against which the present thesis can be tested. The second is receptional: the film's iconography (the bandage costume, the Multipass, the blue Diva) circulates in fan production as a repertoire of what Warburg called pathos-formulae, and its afterlife may be traced with his methods. The third is comparative: the relational soteriologies that the late 1990s produced in *The Fifth Element* and *The Matrix* invite a broader study of how popular cinema since the millennium has imagined the saving of a world—and whether it has remembered that the saving power, where it appears, grows between persons.

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Keywords

Coinages of this dissertation:

metaxic quintessentialism; pemptic inversion; theurgic inversion; osculatory theodicy; sociocosmic tetrasomia; medial quintessence; carnivalesque sublime; cosmogonic non-annihilation; counter-kenosis; Karamazov kiss.

Film, media, and visual culture:

Luc Besson; Robert Mark Kamen; *The Fifth Element*; *Le Cinquième Élément*; cinéma du look; neo-baroque; Euro-blockbuster; *bande dessinée*; *Métal hurlant*; Mœbius; Jean-Claude Mézières; Alejandro Jodorowsky; *L'Incal*; *Valérian*; Enki Bilal; Jean Paul Gaultier; costume theory; camp; special-effects sublime; society of the spectacle; culture industry; male gaze; 1997 science-fiction cinema; vertical megacity.

Philosophy:

quintessence; aether; category mistake; relational ontology; substance metaphysics; *metaxu*; Diotima; Empedocles; *Philotēs* and *Neikos*; Heraclitus; Aristotle; Bergson; *durée*; *élan vital*; Heidegger; *Sorge*; *Fürsorge*; *Gestell*; Arendt; natality; *amor mundi*; Camus; the absurd; Levinas; Irigaray; sensible transcendental; Badiou; event; Marion; erotic reduction; Barthes; performative utterance; knowledge argument; archive fever; Benjamin; Angel of History; Agamben; bare life; Foucault; biopower.

Theology and religion:

theodicy; anti-theodicy; problem of evil; post-Auschwitz theology; Hans Jonas; Etty Hillesum; kenosis; incarnation; Grand Inquisitor; Bernard of Clairvaux; theology of the kiss; Shekhinah; cherubim; Lurianic Kabbalah; *shevirat ha-kelim*; *tikkun*; *yiḥud*; theurgy; Teilhard de Chardin; Omega Point; civil religion; *Être suprême*; Gnosticism; Sophia; *felix culpa*.

Mythology, esotericism, and comparative religion:

Chaoskampf; *Urzeit gleich Endzeit*; Apophis; Ma'at; connective justice; Osiris; *Enūma Eliš*; Zoroastrian eschatology; Saoshyant; *frashokereti*; *avatāra*; *pañcamahābhūta*; *ākāśa*; *godai*; *wuxing*; Fifth Sun; New Fire ceremony; eternal return; hieros gamos; alchemy; *coniunctio*; *spiritus mundi*; Ficino; Agrippa; John of Rupescissa; *réalisme fantastique*; ancient-astronaut hypothesis; Warburg; *Nachleben*; Lévi-Strauss; bricolage; mediator; monomyth.

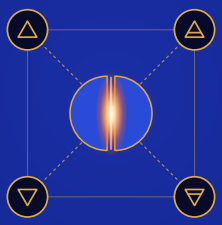
Political economy and violence:

creative destruction; broken-window fallacy; Bastiat; Schumpeter; Bakunin; Maistre; Futurism; military-industrial complex; mimetic theory; René Girard; scapegoat; nonviolence; carnival; Bakhtin.

Science, technology, and the body:

cloning; somatic-cell nuclear transfer; Dolly; genomics; perfect being; android; *L'Ève future*; Frankenstein; golem; Adamic language; Divine Language; perfect language; Yves Klein; International Klein Blue; femme-enfant; Breton; *Arcane 17*.





THE QUINTESSENCE OF THE BETWEEN

Metaxic Soteriology, Osculatory Theodicy, and the Sociocosmic Tetrasomia of Luc Besson and Robert Mark Kamen's The Fifth Element *(1997)*

Written by Claude Opus 5.5
Assembled by Andrew Van Blair

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